Power BI Full Course

Links –

Power BI Interface explained: Views, Panes & Navigation

https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/training/paths/data-analytics-microsoft/

https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/training/paths/power-bi-effective/

Power BI Interface Explained

Learn how the Power BI interface works: Report, Data (Table), and Model views, key panes, and ribbon essentials explained for marketing teams.



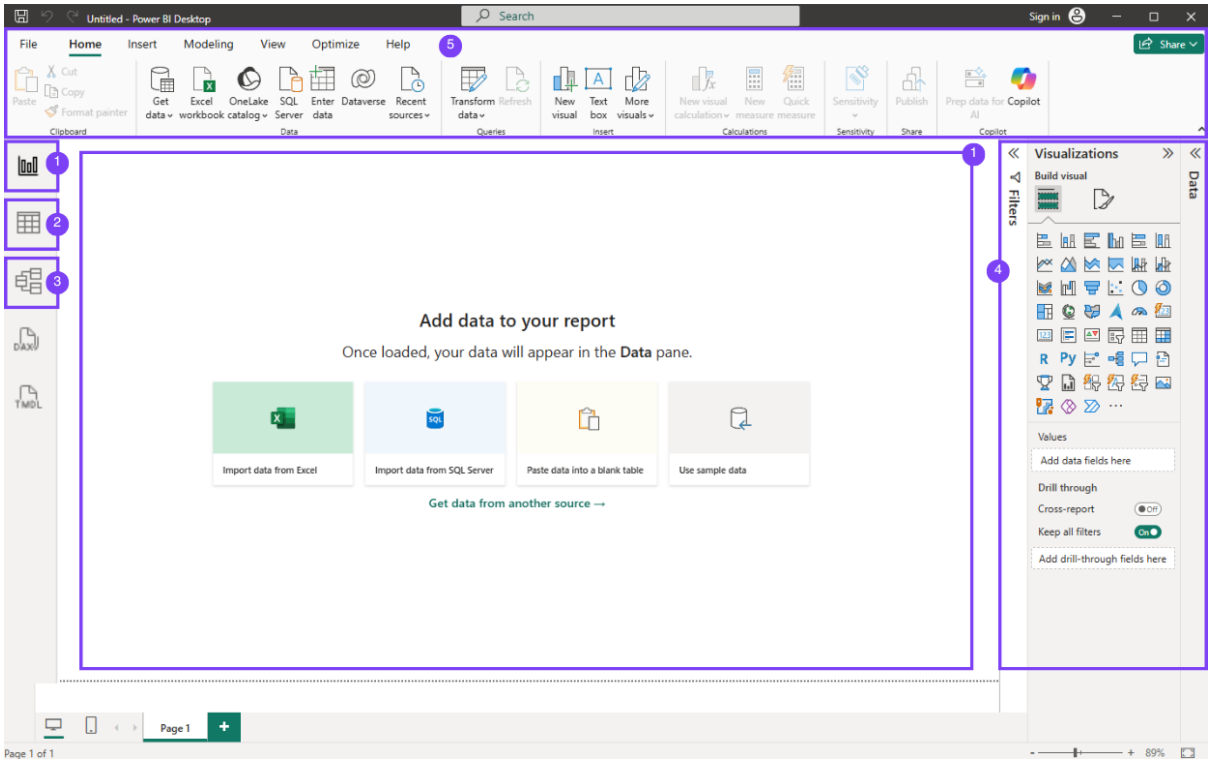
When opening Power BI for the first time, the interface can feel overwhelming. With multiple views, panes, and menus, it's not always obvious where to start. The good news is that it's highly structured. Once you understand how the main views and panes work together, navigating Power BI becomes much easier.

In this article, we'll walk through the interface step by step, focusing on how marketing teams actually use it.

Understanding the Power BI interface

Power BI Desktop is organized around three main views, several side panes, and a top ribbon. Each part of the interface serves a specific purpose, and you don't need to use

everything at once. Most marketing tasks happen in the **Report view (1)**, while the **Data view (2)** and **Model view (3)** are used occasionally to understand or adjust the structure of the data. The **side panes (4)** help you build visuals and apply filters, and the **ribbon (5)** gives access to key actions such as connecting data or publishing reports.

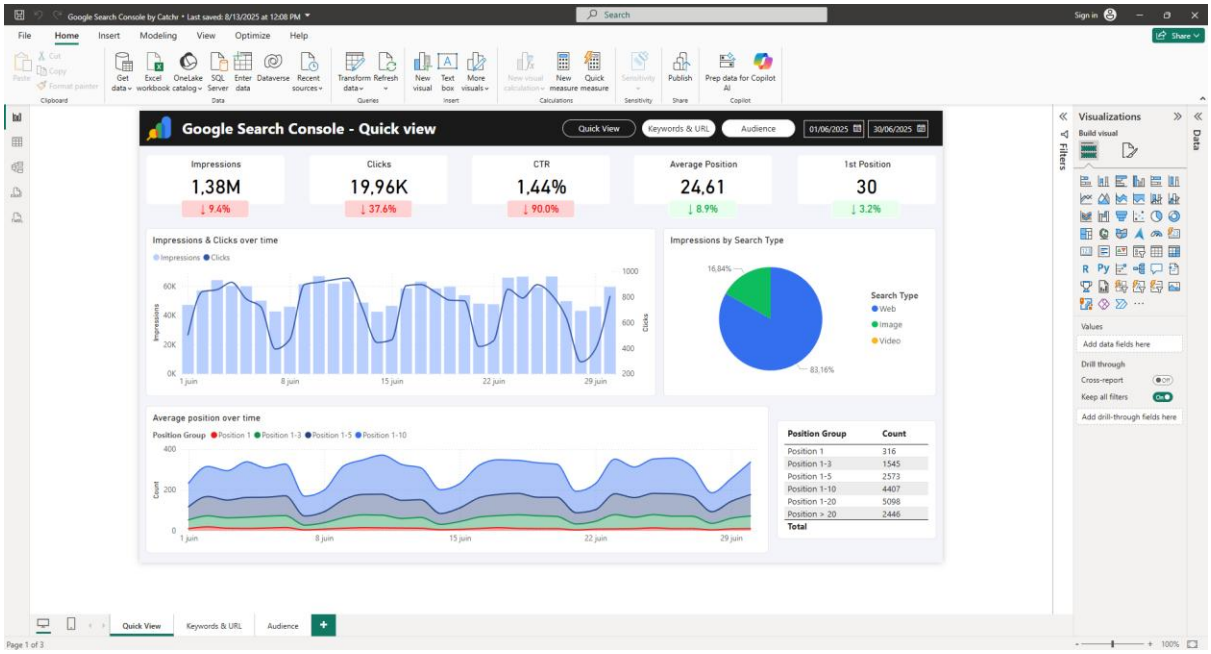


Power BI views explained

The three Power BI views determine what you are working on at any given moment. Knowing when to use each one is essential to avoid confusion and work more efficiently.

Report view in Power BI (building dashboards)

The Report view is where marketing teams spend most of their time. This is the workspace **used to build** dashboards and reports by adding visuals to report pages.

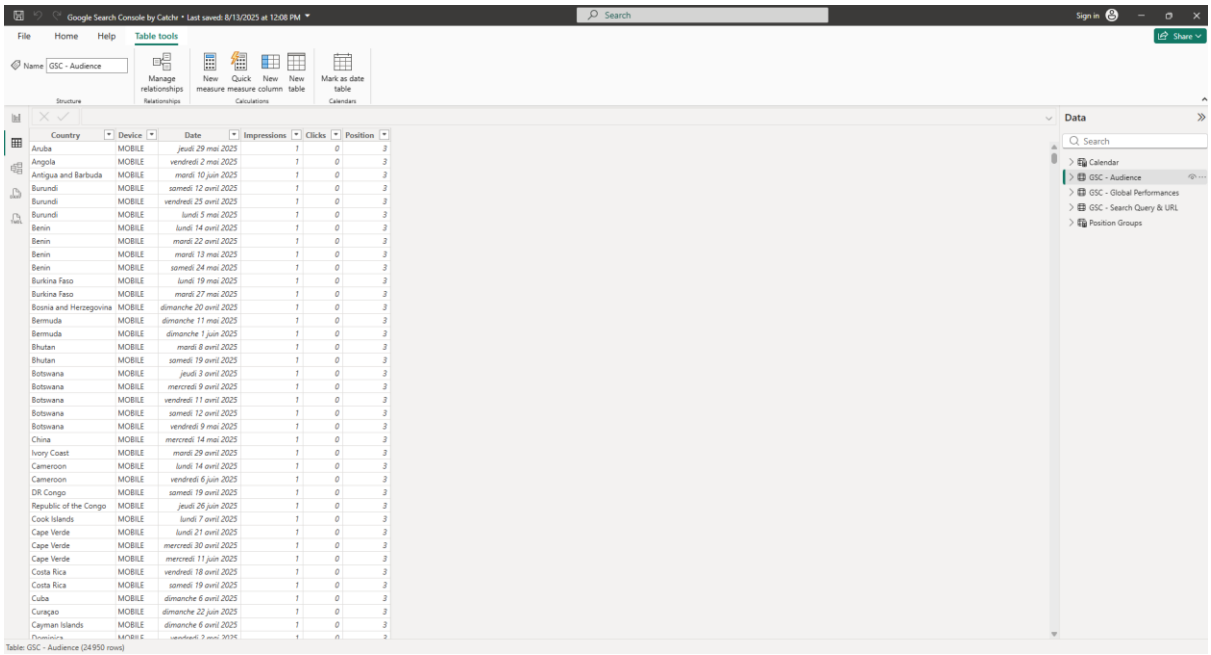


In Report view, you can create charts and tables, add slicers and filters, arrange visuals on the canvas, and format them for readability. This is also where you create multiple pages within a report to cover different marketing perspectives, such as acquisition, channel performance, or funnel analysis. Page tabs appear at the bottom of the Report view, letting you add new pages and quickly switch between them.

Report view is the default and primary view.

Data view in Power BI (understanding your data)

The **Data view**, represented by the **table icon** in the interface and sometimes called the **Table view**, displays the data loaded into Power BI in a tabular format.

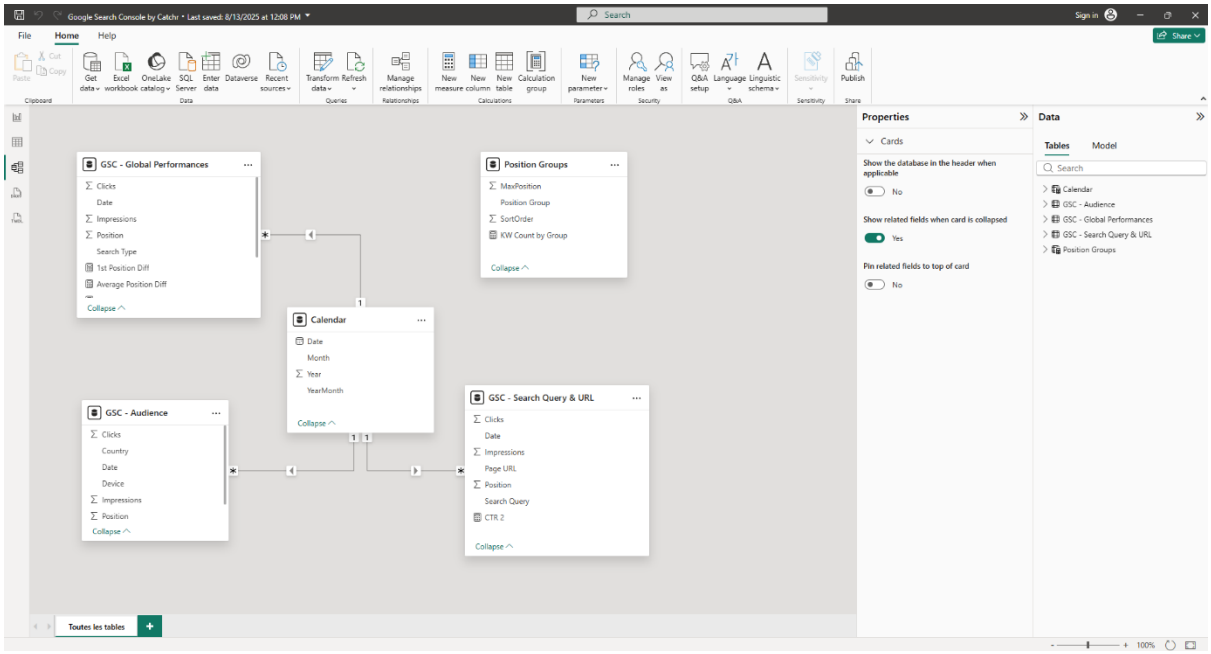


Marketing teams typically use it to quickly check values, understand which columns and fields are available, verify data types, or troubleshoot unexpected results in a report. Keep in mind that this view is **read-only**: it looks like a spreadsheet, but it isn't meant for editing data like Excel.

Its purpose is to help you validate and understand your data without changing the underlying structure.

Model view in Power BI (relationships and structure)

The Model view shows how tables are connected to each other through relationships. It provides a visual representation of how data flows across the model.



This view is especially useful when filters or KPIs don't behave as expected. For example, if a date filter does not affect all visuals, the issue is often visible in the relationships shown in the Model view.

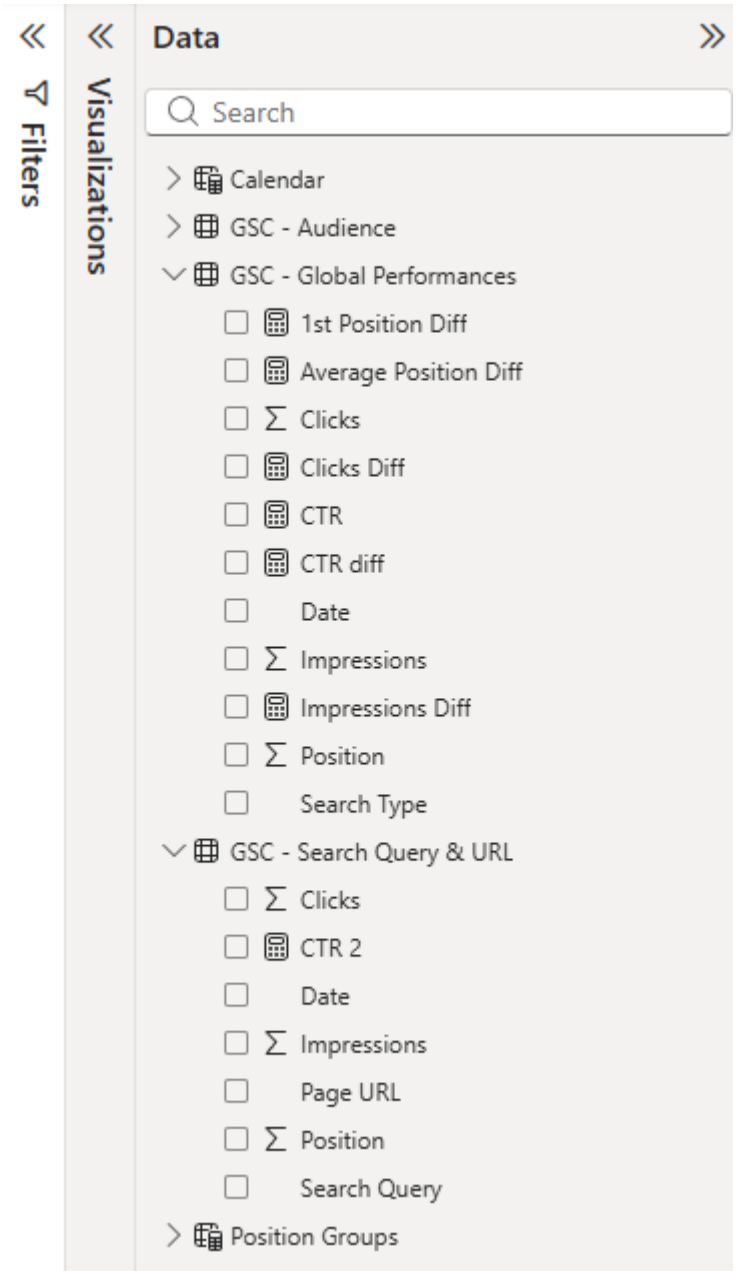
Marketers don't need to work in this view constantly, but understanding its role is essential because changes made here affect the entire report.

Power BI panes explained

The right-hand panes in Power BI are core to how you build and manage reports. In this section, we'll focus specifically on the panes in **Report view**, which you use to add visuals, control how data is displayed, and apply filters.

Data pane in Power BI

The Fields pane lists all tables, columns, and measures available in your report. This is where you choose which data appears in your visuals.

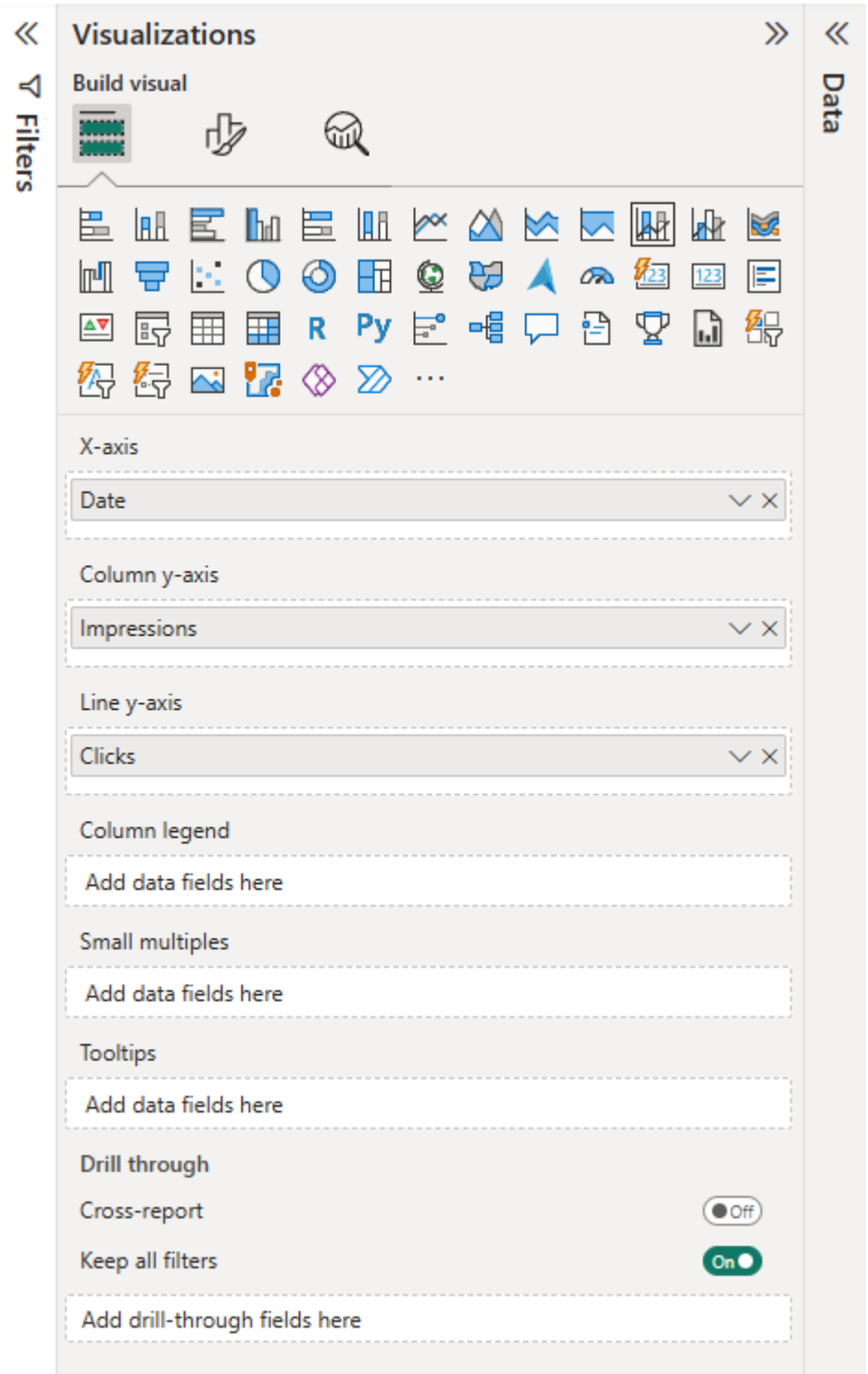


For example, with a Google Search Console dataset, the Fields pane typically **includes metrics** like Clicks, Impressions, CTR, and Average position, **plus dimensions** such as Query, Page, Country, Device, and Date. To build a visual, drag a metric into **Values** and a dimension into the **Axis**, **Legend**, or **Filters**.

This pane is where you decide what you want to analyze and how data should be broken down.

Visualizations pane in Power BI

The Visualizations pane controls how your data is displayed. It lets you select chart types and define how fields from the Fields pane are used inside a visual.

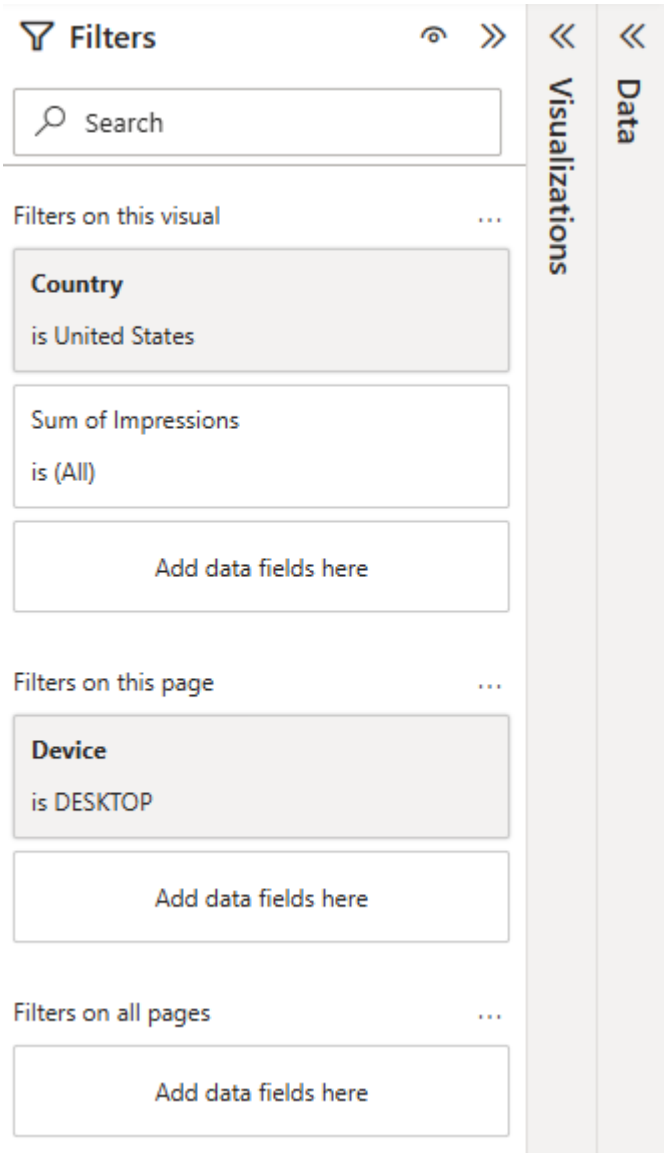


With Search Console data, this pane lets you build common SEO visuals such as tables for top queries or pages, line charts to track performance over time, or comparisons by country or device. For example, you can create a **line chart** with **Date** on the axis and **Clicks** and **Impressions** as values to analyze trends.

This is where analytical questions turn into readable visuals.

Filters pane in Power BI

The Filters pane controls which data is included in a visual, a page, or the entire report. Filters can be applied at different levels, which is why they are often a source of confusion for beginners.



For example, you might filter a page to only show data for desktop traffic, or apply a visual-level filter to display only performances for a specific country.

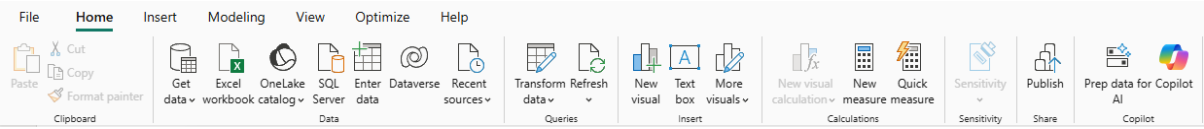
Understanding filter levels helps explain why some visuals change when interacting with the report, while others remain unchanged.

Power BI ribbon essentials for marketers

The ribbon at the top of Power BI Desktop includes many options, but most marketers rely on a small set of actions on a daily basis. The good news is that the essentials are all available in the **Home** tab, and you can then explore other tabs when you need more specific features.

The most commonly used actions are:

- **Get data** (connect to a data source)
- **Transform data** (open Power Query to clean and reshape data)
- Refresh (update the dataset)
- **New measure** (create KPIs such as ROAS, CAC, or conversion rate)
- **Publish** (send your report to Power BI Service)



While the **Home** tab covers most day-to-day needs, the other ribbon tabs help you go further depending on what you're working on:

- **Home**: core actions for connecting, transforming, refreshing, and publishing
- **Insert**: add visuals, buttons, shapes, and other report elements
- **Modeling**: build measures, manage relationships, and work with your model logic
- **View**: control layout, panes, themes, and on-screen guidance
- **Optimize**: performance-related tools (mostly useful for advanced use cases)
- **Help**: documentation, support, and learning resources

How marketers should navigate the Power BI interface

A simple way to navigate Power BI is to think in terms of intent. When you want to build or adjust visuals, stay in the **Report view**. When you need to check which columns are available or validate specific values, use the **Data (Table) view**. If filters or relationships don't behave as expected, the **Model view** is usually the right place to look. And when your data needs cleaning or reshaping before it can be reported correctly (such as removing duplicates, changing data types, splitting columns, or preparing a date field) use **Transform data** to open **Power Query**.

This mental model helps marketers move through the interface with confidence and know where to act depending on the issue.

What's next?

Now that you understand how Power BI Desktop is structured, views on the left, panes on the right, and key actions in the ribbon, you can navigate the interface with

confidence. Next, you'll start working with real marketing data by connecting a source, preparing it in Power Query, and building your first report.

ShareLink copied

Learning Power BI efficiently

Learn how to use Power BI as a marketer: the right learning approach, the Power BI workflow, how hard it really is, and how long it takes to become operational.

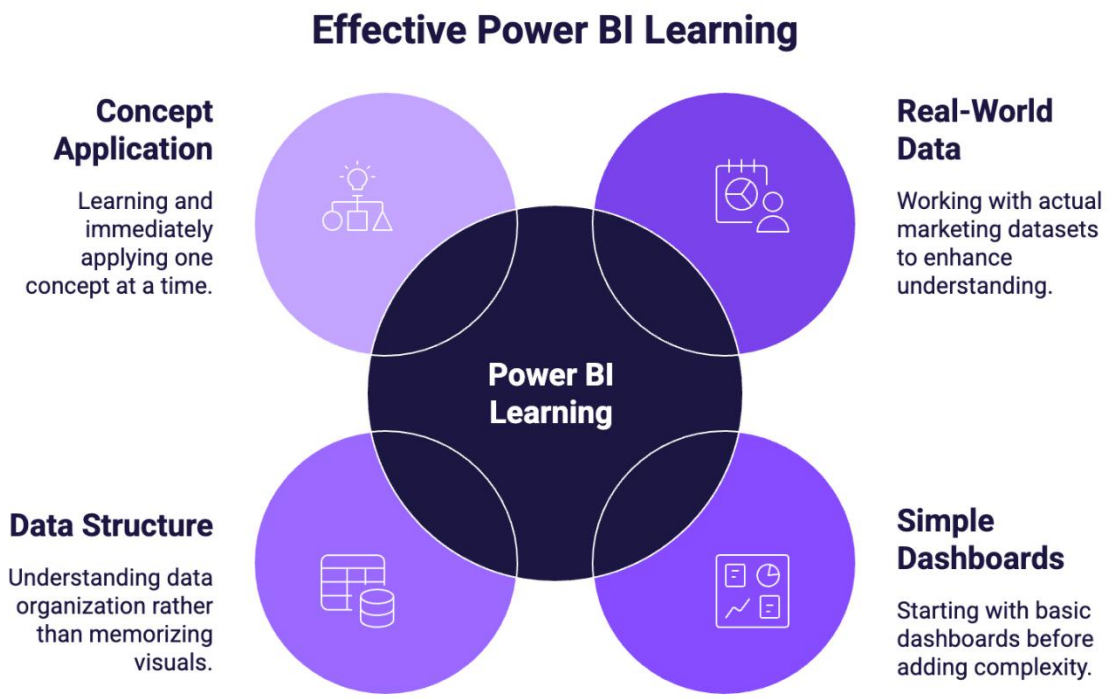


Learning Power BI can feel intimidating at first, especially for marketers who are not used to working with data modeling or BI tools. Power BI looks powerful, and it is, but that doesn't mean it's reserved for data analysts or engineers.

For marketing teams, learning Power BI is mostly about understanding a **clear workflow**, working with **real marketing data**, and focusing on the metrics that matter. In this article, we'll explain how to learn Power BI efficiently, how it is typically used, whether it's easy to learn for marketers, and how long it realistically takes to become operational.

How to learn Power BI (the right way for marketers)

The most effective way to learn Power BI as a marketer is to start with **real use cases**, not features. Instead of trying to learn every menu and option, focus on answering concrete questions such as campaign performance, channel comparison, or funnel conversion.



Power BI is best learned by:

- Working with real marketing datasets (ads, analytics, CRM exports)
- Starting with simple dashboards before adding complexity
- Understanding how data is structured rather than memorizing visuals
- Learning one concept at a time and applying it immediately

Many marketers learn faster by building one real dashboard end to end rather than following long, generic tutorials. Using your own marketing data, such as campaigns, website traffic, or CRM exports, makes the process more concrete and helps you become comfortable answering everyday marketing questions in Power BI.

If you want to avoid manual exports and quickly bring your marketing data into Power BI, tools like Catchr can help. Catchr lets you connect data from more than 80 marketing platforms and send it directly to Power BI, so you can focus on learning dashboards and KPIs instead of managing files. A 14-day free trial is available if you want to experiment with real data while learning.
Start connecting your data to Power BI with Catchr

Is Power BI easy to learn for marketers?

Power BI is easier to learn than it may seem, but it does require a shift in mindset compared to spreadsheets. Creating visuals and using filters is generally intuitive, even

for beginners. The more challenging part is understanding how data tables relate to each other and how metrics are calculated.

For most marketing use cases:

- Advanced DAX is not required at the beginning
- Many dashboards rely on simple calculations
- The main difficulty often comes from messy or inconsistent data, not from Power BI itself

With a clear scope and realistic expectations, most marketers can become productive without a technical background.

How long does it take to learn Power BI? (a realistic timeline)

Learning Power BI is a gradual process, not a one-time step. For marketing teams, progress usually happens in phases rather than levels.

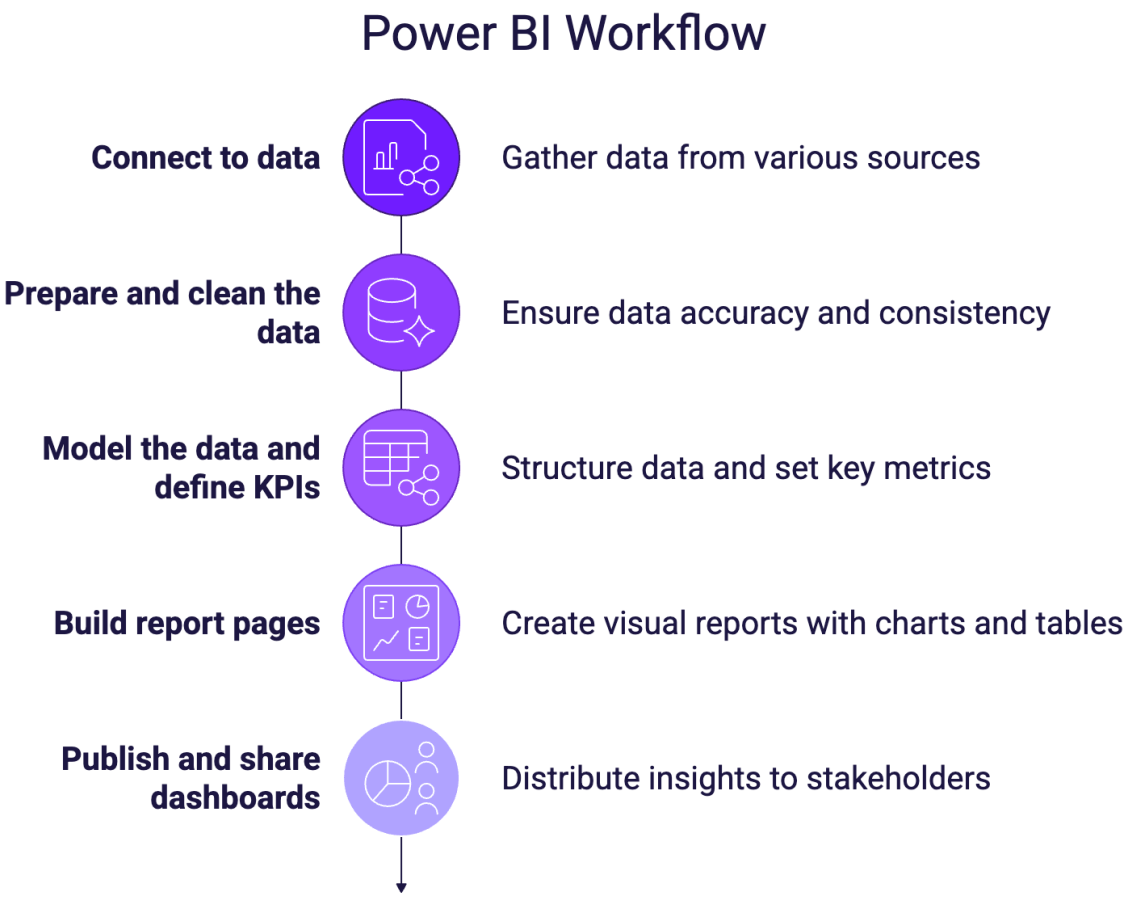
In the first few hours, most users become familiar with the interface, basic visuals, and filters. Within the first week, it's realistic to build a simple marketing dashboard using exported data. After a few weeks of regular use, marketers usually feel comfortable with data modeling basics, KPI definitions, and report structure.

More advanced topics, such as complex DAX formulas, performance optimization, or governance, typically come later and are only needed for specific use cases.

The key is to focus on becoming **operational**, not on mastering every feature.

How to use Power BI (workflow overview)

Power BI follows a consistent workflow that applies to most marketing use cases. Once you understand this flow, the tool becomes much easier to approach.



A typical Power BI workflow looks like this:

1. Connect to data from files, platforms, or databases
2. Prepare and clean the data so it can be analyzed
3. Model the data **and define KPIs**, such as CPA, ROAS, or conversion rate
4. Build report pages with charts, tables, and filters
5. Publish and share dashboards with stakeholders

You don't need to master every step from day one. Most marketers start by connecting simple datasets and building basic reports, then gradually improve data modeling and KPIs as their needs grow.

Common mistakes marketers make when learning Power BI

Many frustrations with Power BI come from a few common mistakes. Marketers often try to start with complex datasets, replicate Excel logic exactly, or focus too much on

visuals before structuring their data properly. Others spend too much time learning advanced DAX before they actually need it.

Avoiding these pitfalls and keeping the scope simple makes the learning process much smoother and more rewarding.

Build your first Marketing Report in Power BI

Learn how to build your first marketing report in Power BI step by step: connect data, create KPIs, add charts, filters, and structure your dashboard properly.



Power BI really starts to make sense once you build something concrete. Instead of exploring features one by one, the best way to learn is to create a simple but real marketing report from start to finish.

In this quick start guide, you'll build your first Power BI dashboard using a basic CSV or Excel export. The goal is not to create a perfect report, but to understand the workflow and end up with something usable.

By the end of this article, you'll have a clean marketing dashboard with KPIs, a trend, a table, and a date filter.

Build your first marketing dashboard step by step

In this section, we'll build a simple marketing dashboard step by step:

1. Connect a CSV or Excel marketing export
2. Create 3 key marketing KPIs
3. Add a trend over time

4. Build a detailed table
5. Add a date slicer
6. Save and structure the report properly

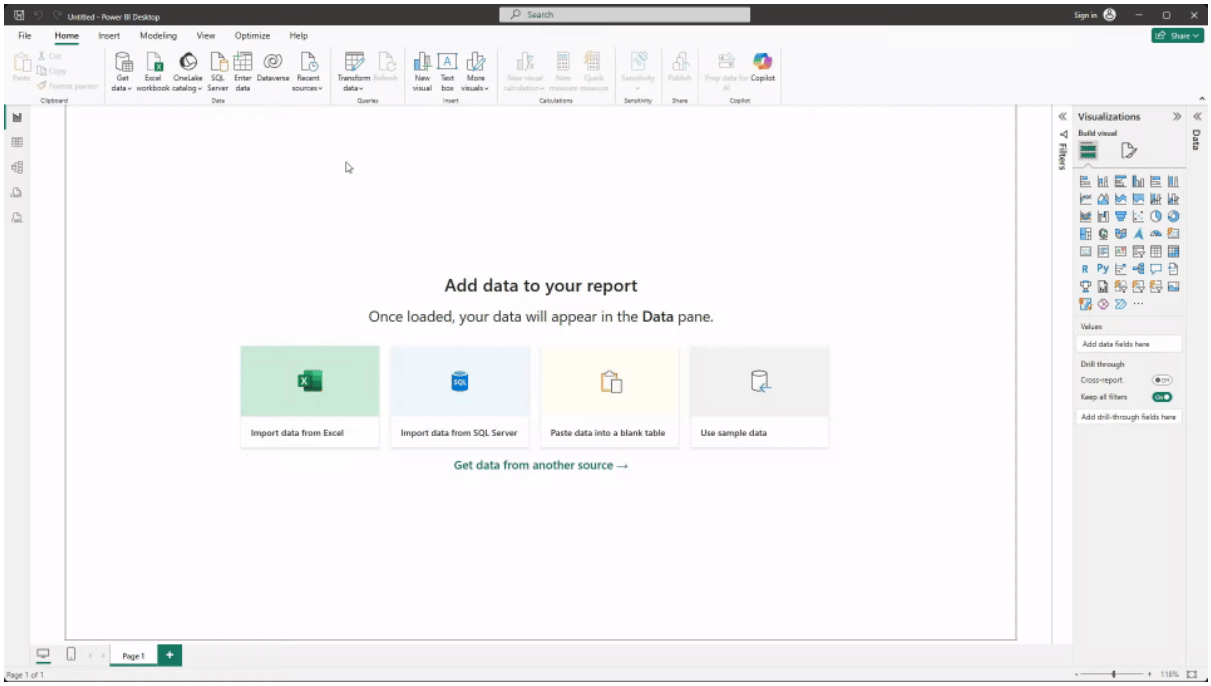
Step 1: Connect to a CSV or Excel marketing export

Start with a simple marketing export, such as data from Google Search Console, Google Analytics, an advertising platform, or a CRM. CSV or Excel files are perfect for learning because they're easy to work with and don't require any setup. In this example, we'll connect data to Power BI using a CSV export from Google Search Console.

In Power BI Desktop:

1. Click **Get data** from the Home tab
2. Select **CSV** or **Excel**, then choose your file

Power BI will preview the data before loading it into the report. This preview lets you quickly check the file structure, column names, and confirm that your metrics are correctly recognized as numeric values. You don't need to clean or transform the data extensively yet. This step is simply about validating that the dataset makes sense before building visuals.

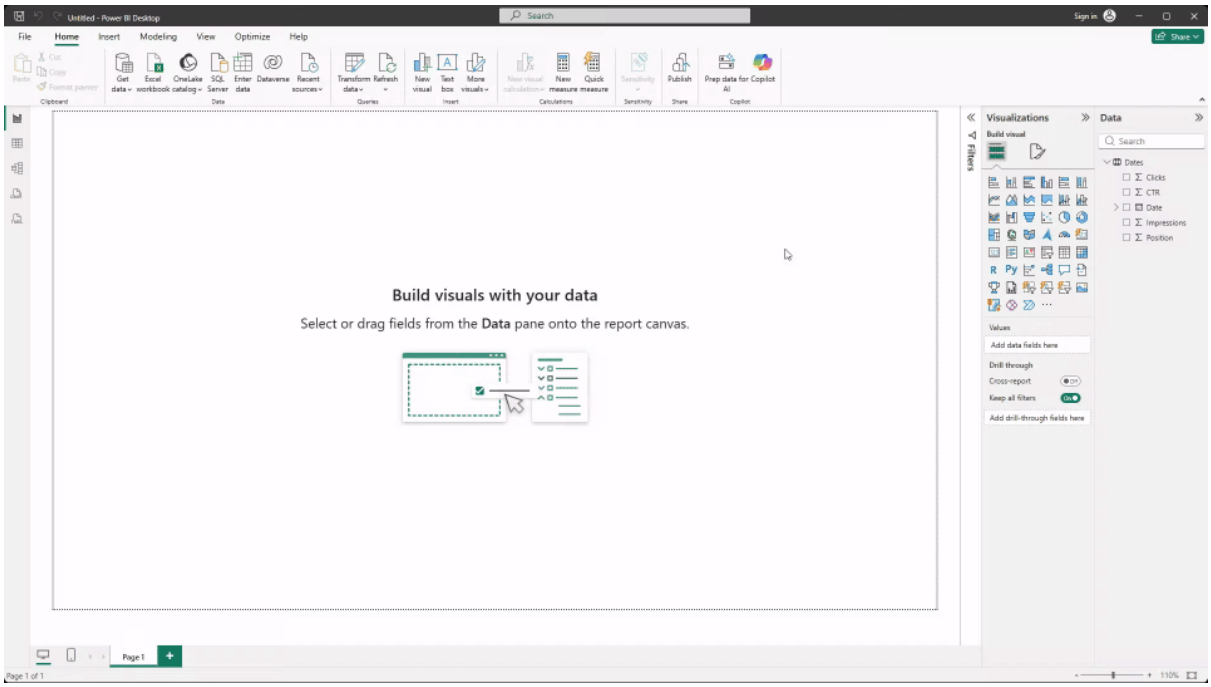


At this stage, don't worry about automation or live connections. The goal is to focus on building your first report.

Step 2: Create 3 key marketing KPIs

Next, create three simple KPIs using **Card** visuals. These KPIs should give a quick overview of performance.

1. Open the **Visualizations** pane.
2. Select the **Card** visual.
3. Drag and drop (or check) the metric you want to display.
4. If needed, adjust the aggregation by clicking the arrow next to the metric in the **Values** section.



Typical examples include total clicks or sessions, total impressions, and conversions or revenue, depending on your dataset. Drag each metric into a separate card and place them at the top of the report.

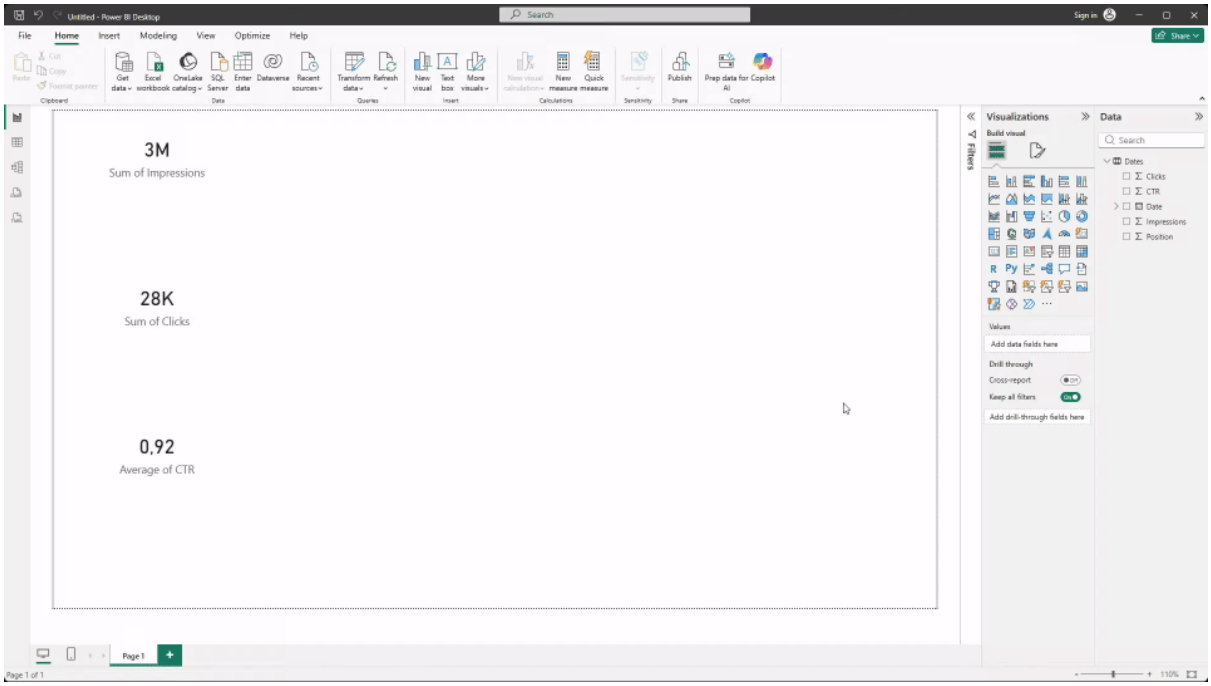
At this stage, basic aggregations are enough. There's no need for advanced calculations or custom measures yet.

You can delete a visual by selecting it and pressing **Delete** on your keyboard, or by clicking the **three dots** on the visual and choosing **Remove**.

Step 3: Add one trend over time

Now that you have a high-level view of performance, you can go deeper by adding a **line chart** to show how metrics evolve over time.

1. Select the Line chart visual
2. Add Date in x-axis
3. Add your metrics in y-axis and secondary y-axis to avoid overwhelming you chart

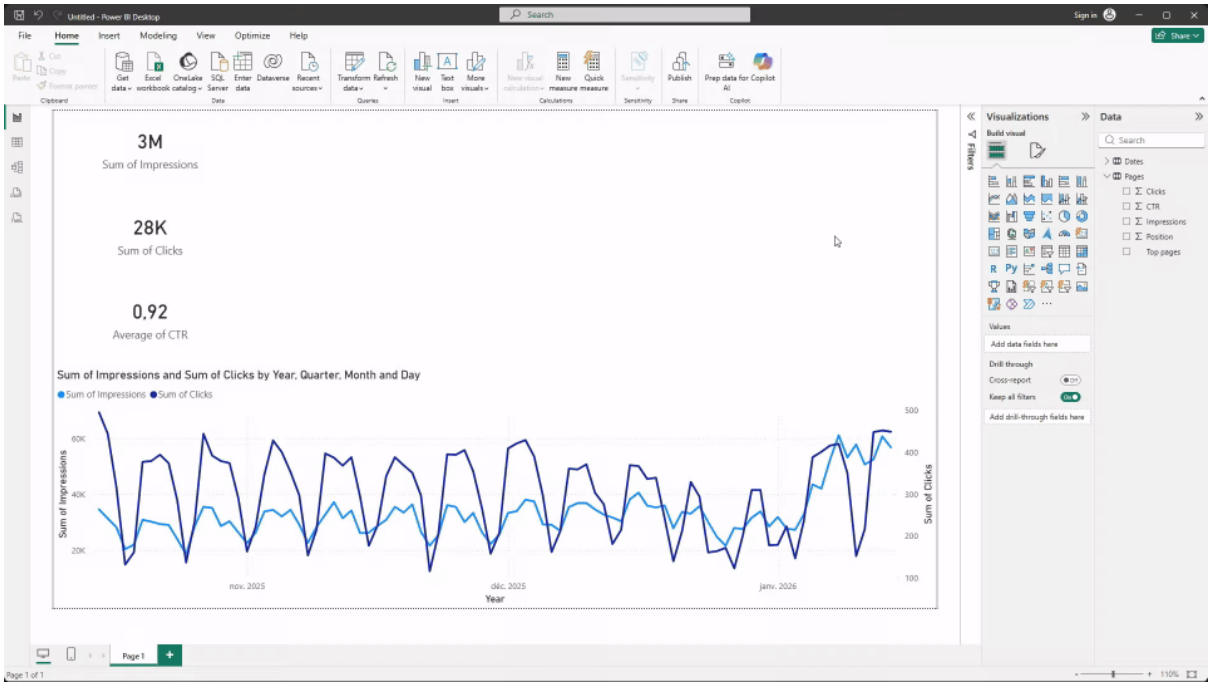


This visual helps identify growth, seasonality, or sudden changes in performance. Keep the chart simple and easy to read.

Step 4: Build one table for detailed analysis

To make the report actionable, add a **Table** visual. Choose one main dimension, such as query, page, campaign, or channel, and add two or three relevant metrics.

1. Select the **Table** visual.
2. Choose the dimensions and metrics you want to display.
3. Adjust the size of the table and resize columns as needed for better readability.



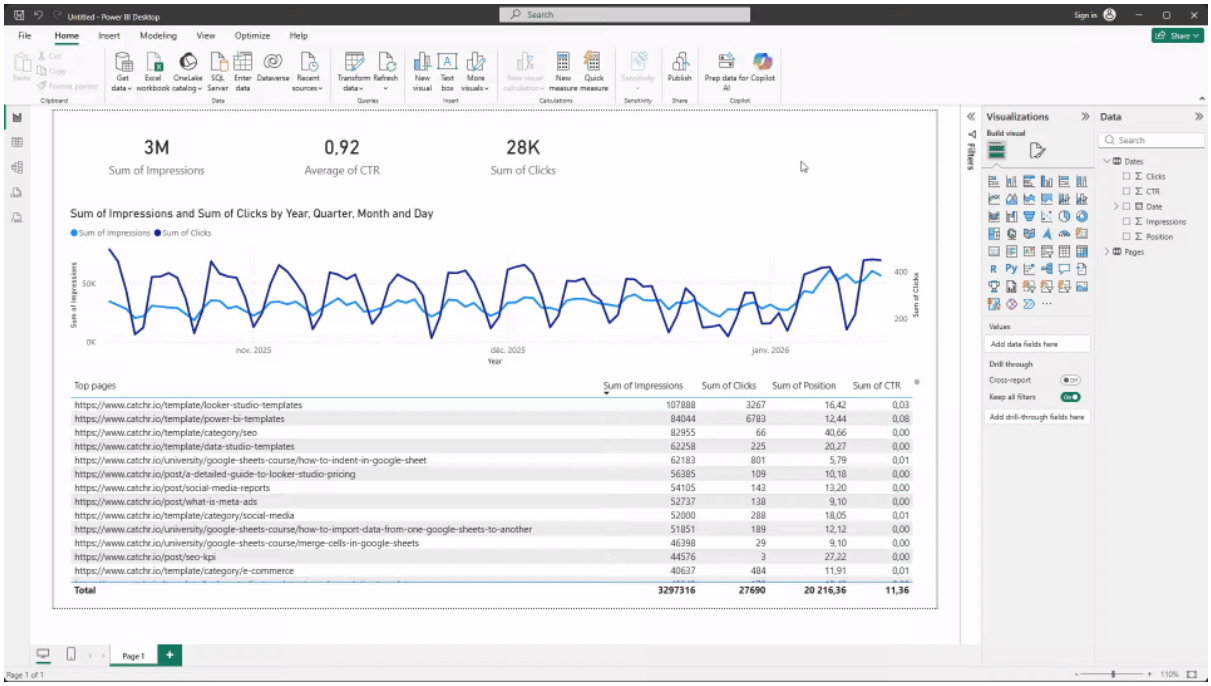
Sort the table by a key metric to quickly identify top-performing or underperforming items. This table allows you to move from high-level insights to more detailed analysis.

Step 5: Add a date slicer

Add a Slicer using your date field so users can control the time period displayed in the report. Place the slicer at the top or side of the page.

1. Select the **Slicer** visual.
2. Add the **Date** field to the slicer.

You can now easily select a time range to filter the entire report.

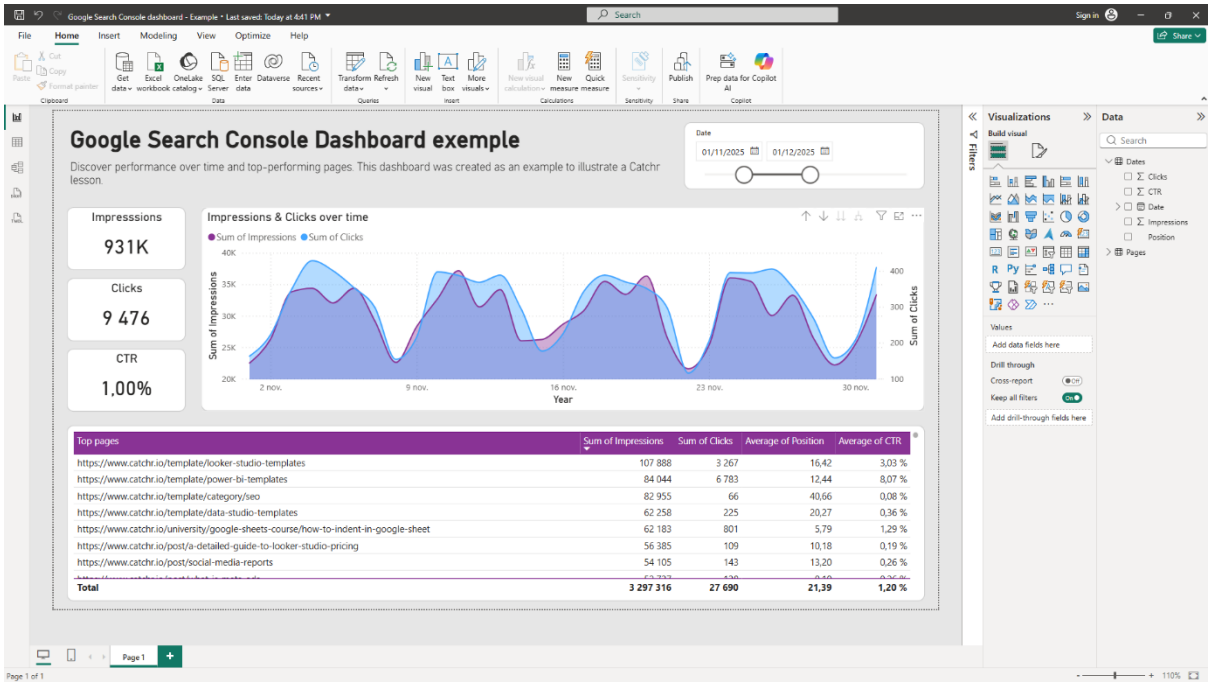


This slicer will filter all visuals on the page, allowing you to explore performance over different periods without changing the report structure.

Step 6: Save and structure your report properly

Before moving on, take a moment to organize and refine your report.

- Rename the page with a clear, meaningful title.
- Rename visuals so they’re easy to understand.
- Adjust spacing and alignment to keep the layout clean and readable.
- Improve the look and feel by selecting a visual and using **Format your visual** (titles, colors, borders, labels, spacing).
- Save the file using a clear naming convention.



These small habits make a big difference as your reports grow and get shared, and we'll dive deeper into dashboard design in a dedicated lesson.

Common beginner mistakes to avoid

When starting out, it's easy to add too many visuals or track too many KPIs at once. Another common mistake is spending too much time on formatting before the data structure is solid.

Focus on clarity and usefulness first. You can always refine and improve the report later.

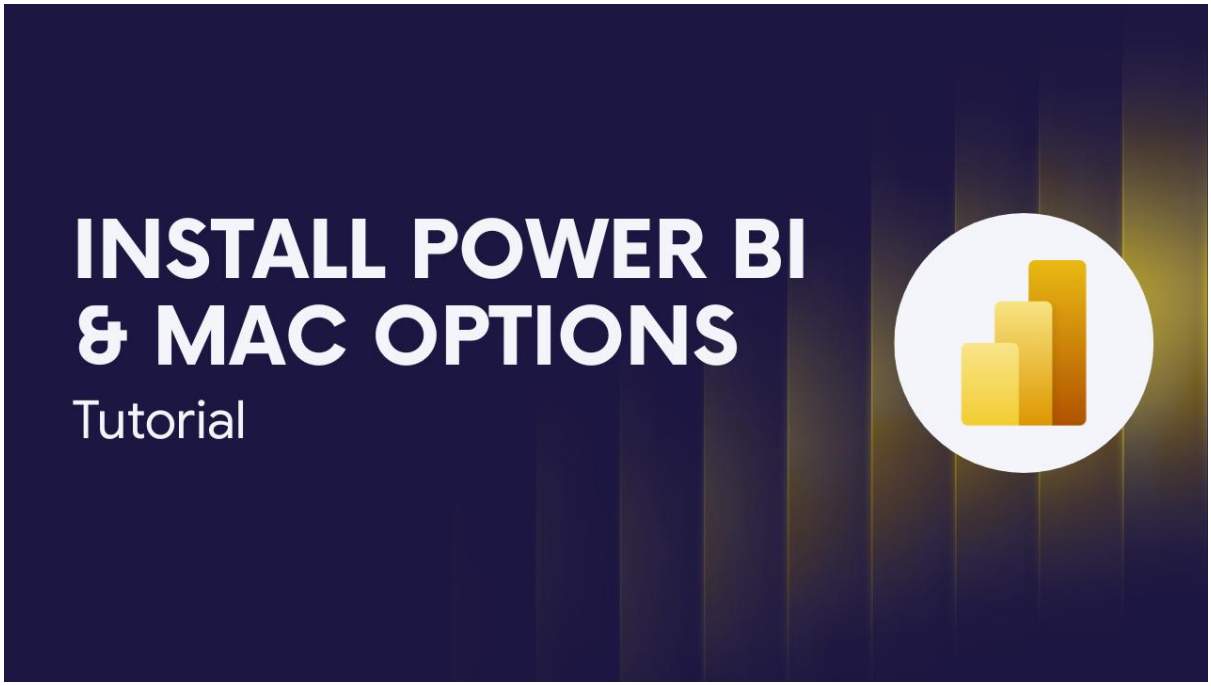
What's next

You've built your first Power BI marketing report and learned the core workflow. The next steps typically involve preparing and cleaning data more thoroughly with Power Query, improving KPI definitions, or connecting live data sources instead of manual exports.

From here, you can continue building more advanced dashboards or explore platform-specific examples to deepen your Power BI skills.

Install Power BI & Mac options

Learn how to install Power BI on Windows, whether Power BI works on Mac, and the best options for Mac users to access or build marketing dashboards.



Installing Power BI is usually straightforward, but it often raises questions for marketing teams, especially when different operating systems are involved. Power BI Desktop is a Windows application, yet many marketers work on macOS and still need to access dashboards or build reports.

In this article, you'll learn how to install Power BI on Windows, whether Power BI works on Mac, and which options are available for Mac users depending on their role.

How to download Power BI on Windows

If you are using Windows, installing Power BI is quick and simple. Power BI Desktop is the main tool used to build reports, model data, and create dashboards.

What you need before installing Power BI

Before installing Power BI Desktop, make sure the following requirements are met:

- A Windows operating system (64-bit recommended)
- Sufficient permissions to install applications on your machine
- A Microsoft account (not required to install or start using Power BI, but needed later to publish or share reports)

Installing Power BI Desktop

Power BI Desktop can be downloaded directly from Microsoft. You have two main options:

- Download it from the Microsoft Store
- Download it from the official Power BI website

Once downloaded, the installation follows a standard setup process. After installation, you can open Power BI Desktop immediately and start working with data.

At this stage, Power BI Desktop works locally and does not require you to sign in. You can explore the interface, connect to files, and build reports without any account.

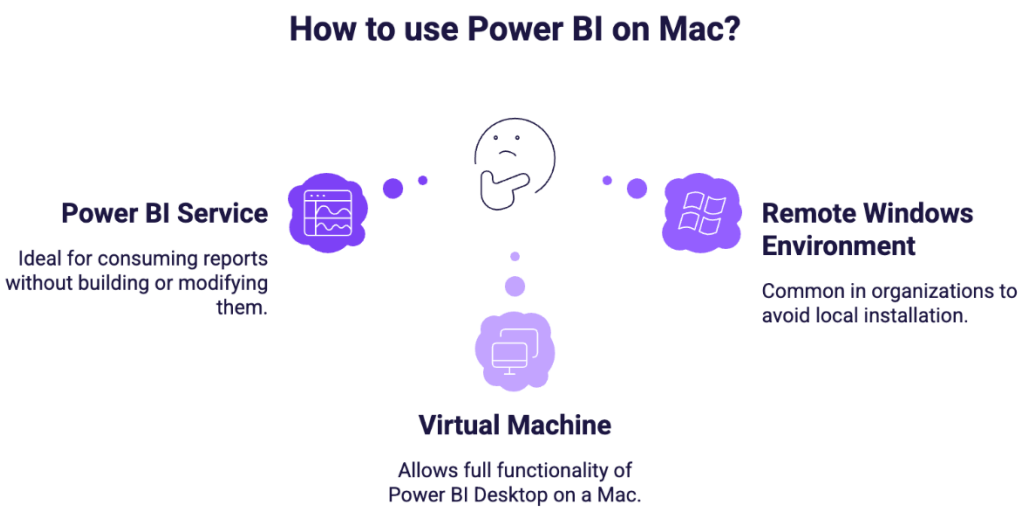
Does Power BI work on Mac?

Power BI Desktop does **not** run natively on macOS. There is currently no Mac version of the Desktop application, so it cannot be installed directly on a Mac.

That said, Power BI is not completely unavailable to Mac users. **Power BI Service**, the web-based version of Power BI, works in any modern browser and can be accessed on macOS without any issue.

Best options for Mac users

Mac users can choose between several options depending on whether they need to **view dashboards** or **build reports**.



Use Power BI Service in the browser

This is the simplest option for Mac users. With Power BI Service, you can:

- View dashboards and reports
- Interact with filters and slicers
- Explore data through visuals

This option is ideal for managers and stakeholders who consume reports but do not need to build or modify them. However, advanced modeling and report creation are not possible without Power BI Desktop.

Use a virtual machine (VM)

Running Windows on a Mac through a virtual machine (such as Parallels or VMware) allows you to use Power BI Desktop with full functionality.

This option is suitable if you:

- Build dashboards regularly
- Need full access to data modeling and report design
- Prefer working from a single device

The main trade-off is additional setup and resource usage.

Use a remote Windows environment

Another option is to access Power BI Desktop through a remote Windows machine, such as:

- A company-managed Windows laptop
- A cloud-based Windows environment

In this setup, Power BI Desktop runs remotely, and the Mac is used only to access it. This approach is common in larger organizations and avoids installing Windows locally.

Which option should marketers choose?

The best option depends on your role and how you use Power BI:

- **Mac users who only view dashboards** can rely on Power BI Service
- **Mac users who build reports** should use a virtual machine or a remote Windows setup

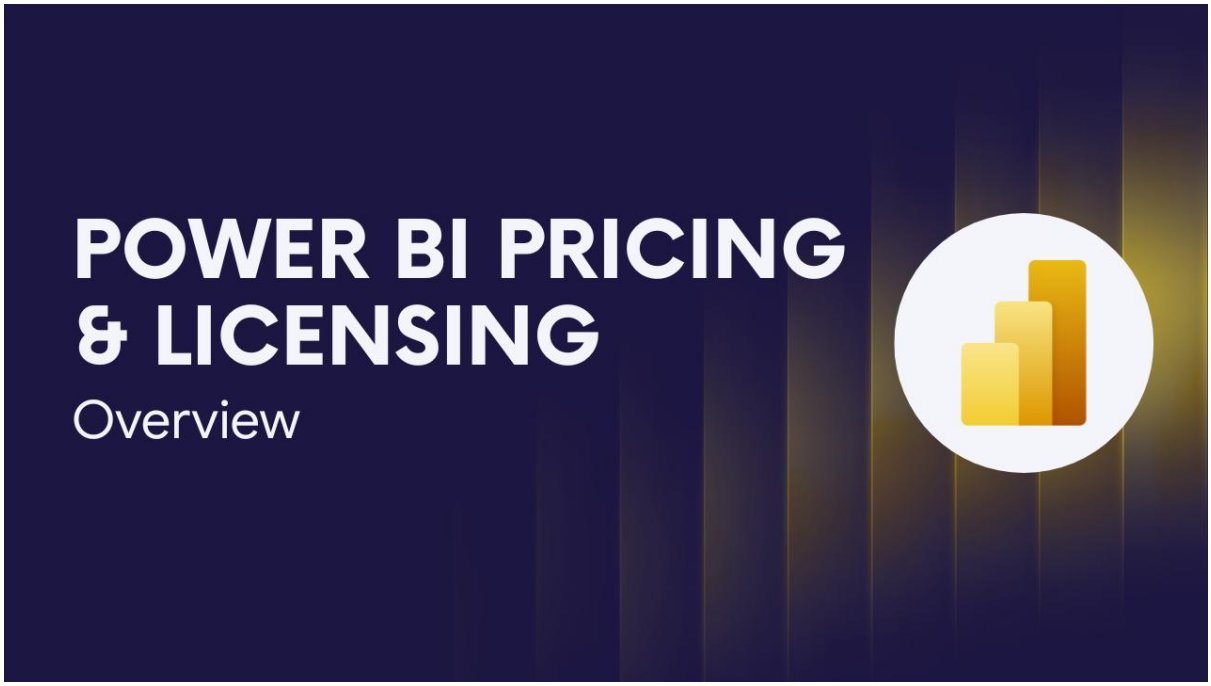
Most marketing teams end up combining Power BI Desktop for report creation and Power BI Service for sharing and collaboration.

What's next?

Once Power BI is installed or accessible on your device, the next step is to connect your marketing data and start building your first dashboard.

Power BI pricing & licensing for marketing teams

Compare Power BI Free, Pro, Premium Per User, and Premium capacity with price ranges, and learn what marketing teams typically need to share and automate dashboards.



Power BI pricing and licensing can be confusing for marketing teams, especially when moving from personal dashboards to shared and automated reporting. While Power BI is often described as “free,” that is only true in specific situations and quickly changes once collaboration or automation is required.

In this article, we explain whether Power BI is free, break down the different licensing options with indicative prices, clarify what is included in Microsoft 365, and summarize what marketing teams usually need in practice.

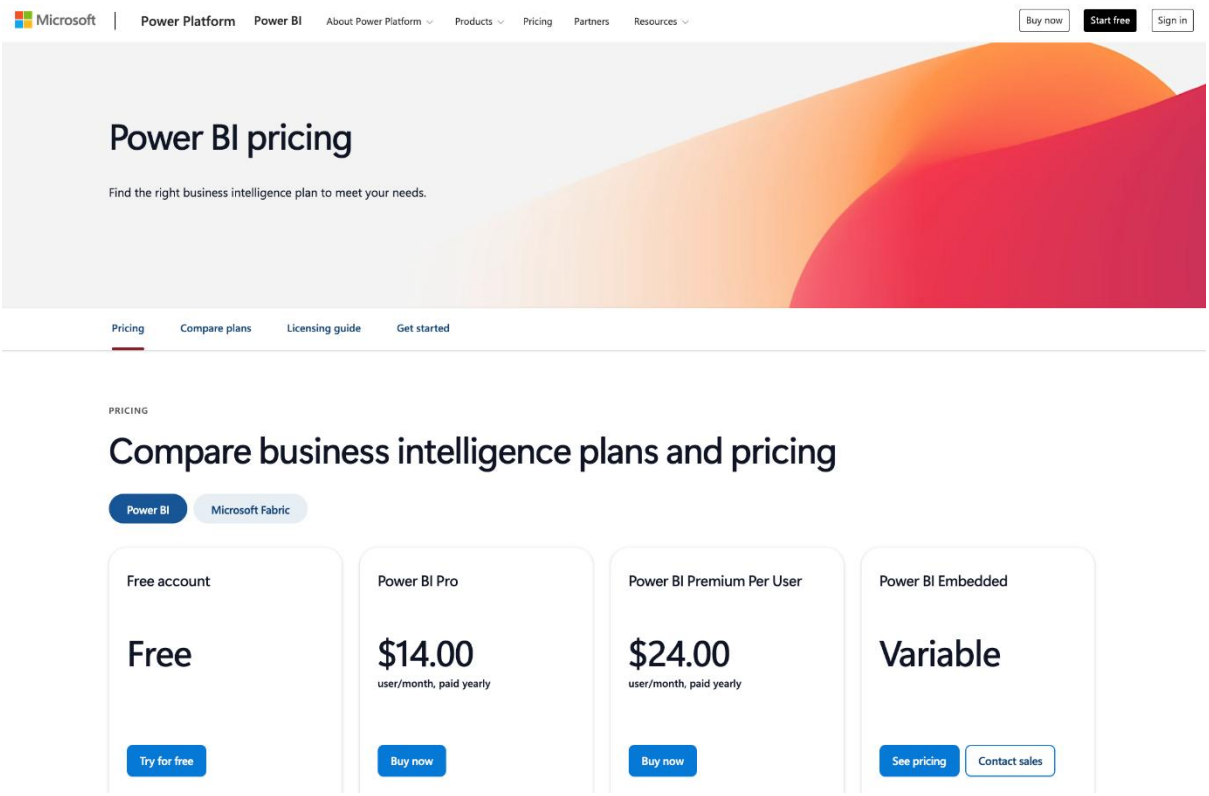
Is Power BI free?

Power BI is free to use **only for building reports locally**. With Power BI Desktop, marketers can connect to data, prepare it, create KPIs, and design dashboards on their own computer at no cost.

However, the free version is limited to individual use. You cannot publish reports, share dashboards with others, collaborate in workspaces, or schedule automated refresh. As soon as marketing reporting needs to be shared or kept up to date automatically, a paid license becomes necessary.

In short, Power BI is free to learn and experiment with, but not sufficient for team-based marketing reporting.

Power BI pricing explained



Power BI licensing is primarily based on **how reports are shared and consumed**, not on how they are built. Prices may vary slightly by region and currency, but the ranges below reflect what marketing teams typically encounter.

License	Indicative price	What it enables (marketing-first)	Typical marketing scenarios
Power BI Free	Free	Build reports locally in Power BI Desktop. Ideal for learning, testing, and personal analysis, but not suitable for sharing or collaboration.	Solo marketer or individual contributor working on personal dashboards.
Power BI Pro	~$14 per user / month	Publish reports to Power BI Service, share dashboards, collaborate in workspaces, and schedule automated refresh.	Small to mid-size marketing teams that need shared, automated reporting.

License	Indicative price	What it enables (marketing-first)	Typical marketing scenarios
Power BI Premium Per User (PPU)	~$24 per user / month	Includes all Pro features plus advanced capabilities such as larger datasets and higher refresh limits.	International teams or agencies with more complex reporting needs.
Power BI Premium capacity	From ~$4,995 per month	Dedicated enterprise capacity allowing a large number of viewers without individual Pro licenses.	Very large organizations with many report consumers and high data volumes.

⚠️ These prices are indicative and may change over time, but they provide a realistic view of Power BI's cost structure for marketing teams.

Is Power BI included in Microsoft 365 or Office 365?

Power BI is **not fully included** in Microsoft 365 or Office 365 by default. While some Microsoft plans allow limited viewing capabilities, publishing, sharing, and managing Power BI content require a dedicated Power BI license such as Pro or Premium.

For marketing teams, this is an important distinction. Having Microsoft 365 does not automatically mean you can use Power BI for collaborative reporting.

What marketing teams usually need

In practice, most marketing teams do not need complex or enterprise-level licensing. A common and effective setup is:

- **Power BI Desktop (free)** to build and test reports
- **Power BI Pro** to publish, share dashboards, and automate refresh

Premium Per User can be useful for more advanced teams dealing with larger datasets or higher refresh needs, while Premium capacity is generally reserved for large organizations with a high number of dashboard viewers.

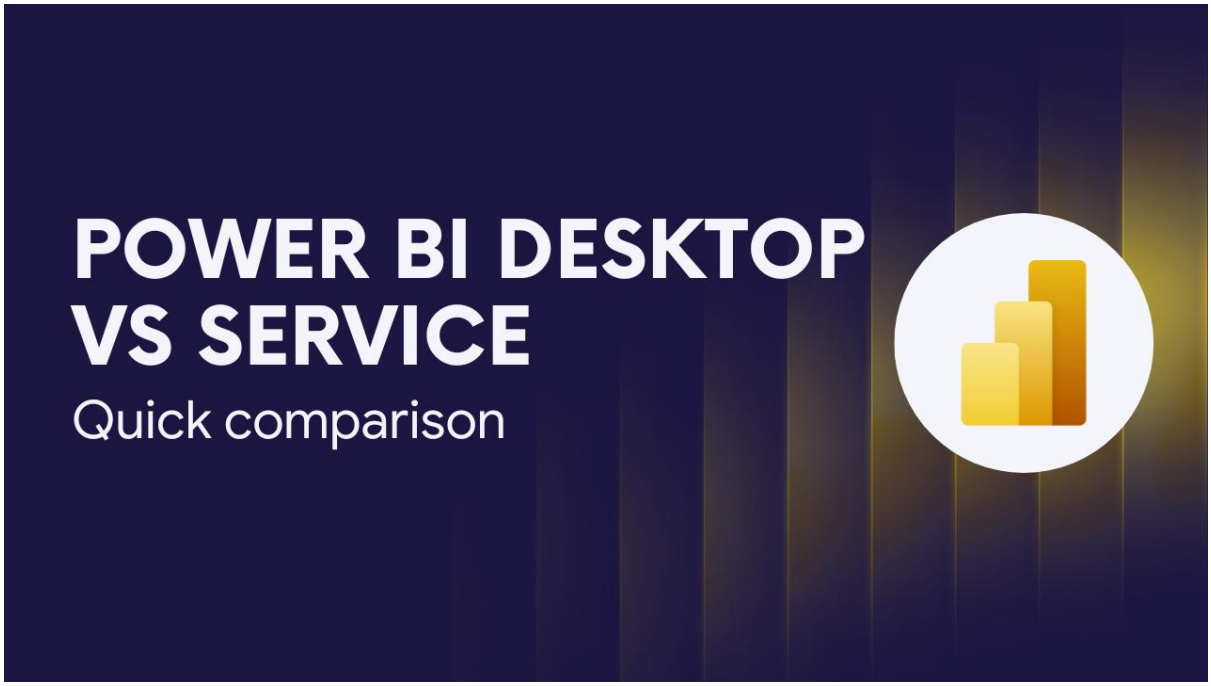
For the majority of marketing teams, Power BI Desktop combined with Power BI Pro offers the best balance between functionality, scalability, and cost.

What's next?

Now that you understand Power BI pricing and licensing, the next step is to install Power BI Desktop and start working with real marketing data, or move on to connecting your data sources and building your first marketing dashboard in Power BI.

Differences between Power BI Desktop and Service

Power BI Desktop vs Power BI Service: a complete guide to what they are, what they're used for, and when to use each one.



If you're new to Power BI, one of the first questions you'll face is the difference between **Power BI Desktop** and **Power BI Service**. Both are part of the same ecosystem, but they serve different purposes and are used at different stages of the reporting workflow.

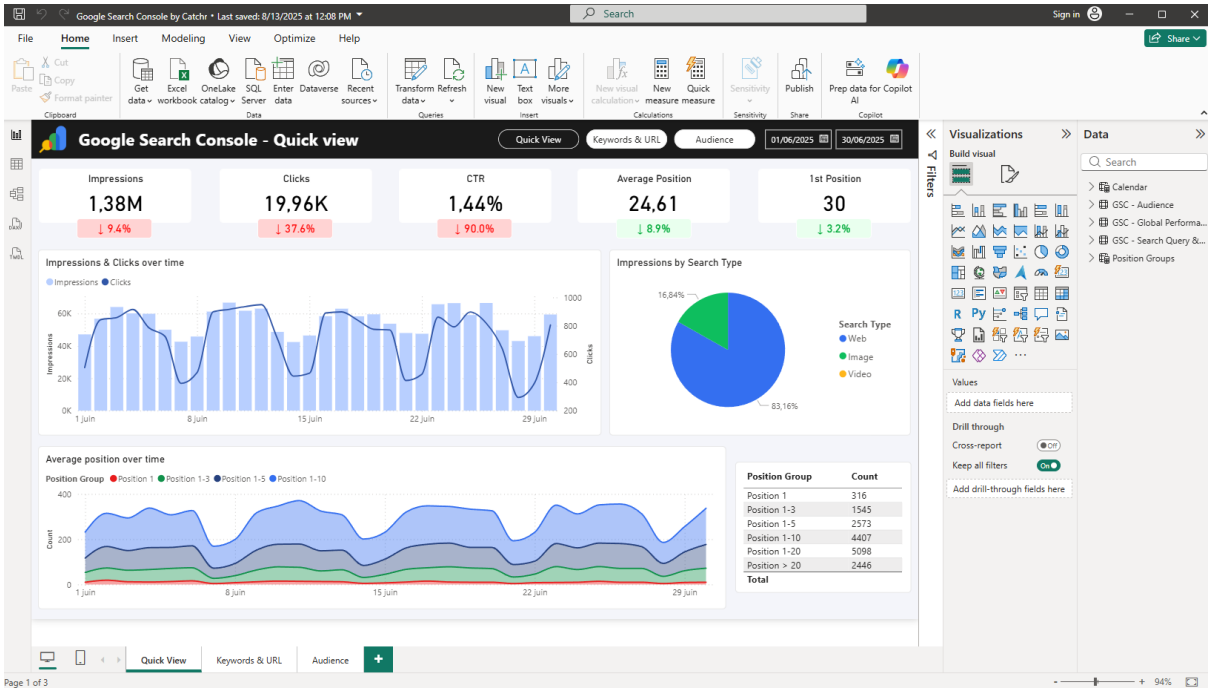
Power BI Desktop is where you build reports and data models, and Power BI Service is where you publish, share, and manage them. Most marketing teams use both.

What is Power BI Desktop?

Power BI Desktop is a **Windows application** used to create Power BI reports. It's where you connect to data, shape it, model it, and design your report pages.

In Power BI Desktop, you typically:

- Connect to data sources (files, databases, online services)
- Clean and transform data (Power Query)
- Build a data model (tables, relationships, date table)
- Create KPIs and calculations (measures)
- Design report pages (charts, tables, filters)



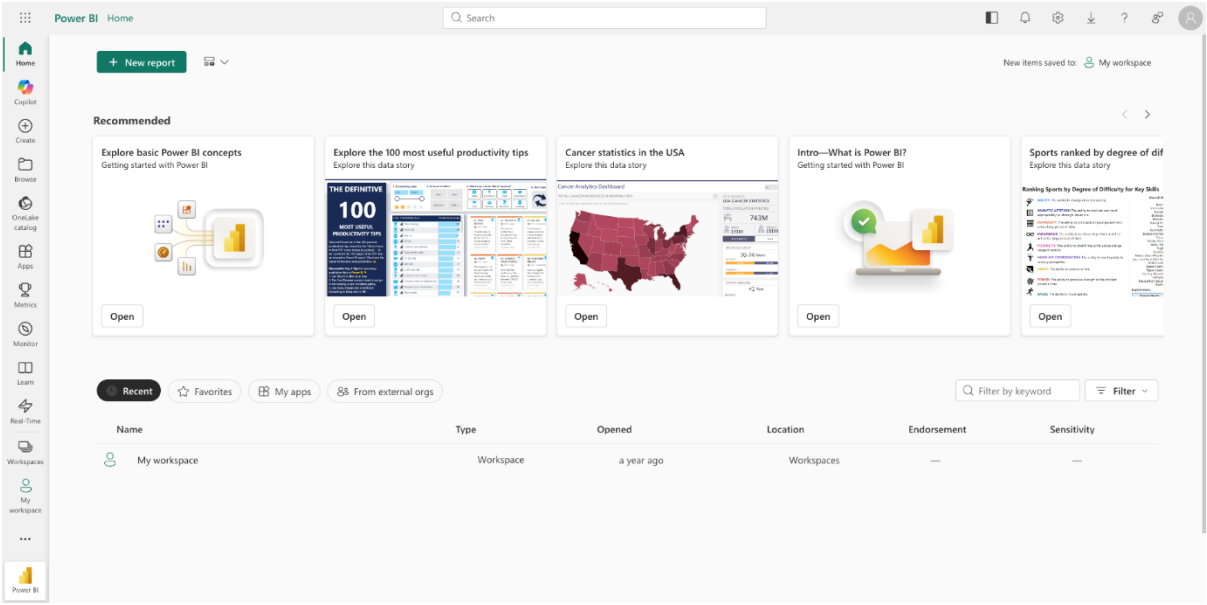
Power BI Desktop runs locally on your computer and is **free to use**, which makes it the starting point for most marketers who want to build dashboards. However, you will quickly be limited if you want to publish or share your reports, as these features require a paid license. We have already published a dedicated article explaining Power BI pricing in detail.

What is Power BI Service?

Power BI Service is the **cloud platform** where Power BI content lives once it has been published. It is accessed through a browser and is designed for collaboration, sharing, and report operations.

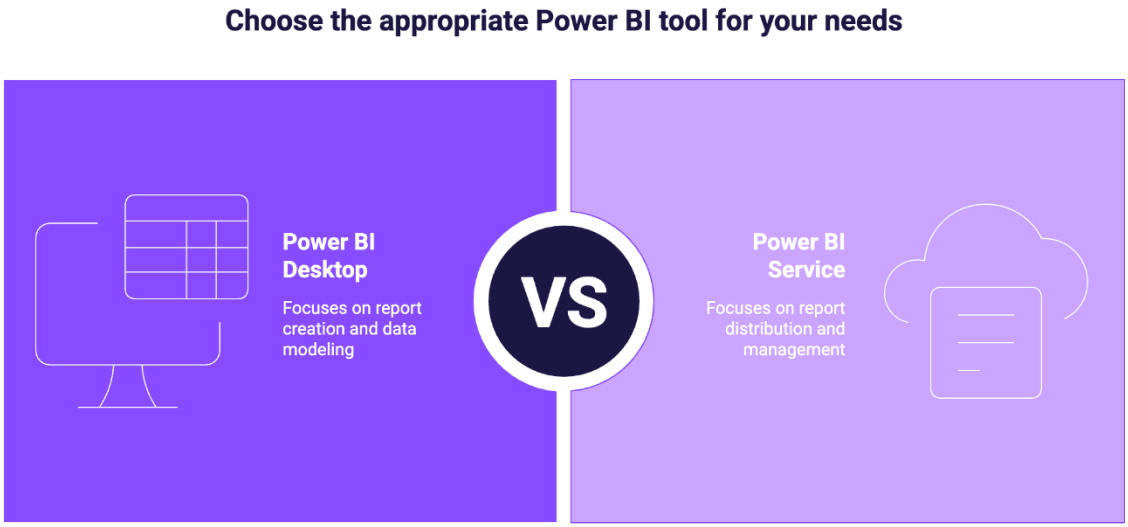
In Power BI Service, marketing teams typically:

- Publish reports from Desktop
- Share reports with stakeholders
- Manage access and permissions
- Schedule data refreshes (automation)
- Organize content in workspaces
- Create dashboards from report visuals



Power BI Service is where most stakeholders view reports, especially people who don't build dashboards themselves. Sharing usually requires a license, depending on your setup.

Power BI Desktop vs Power BI Service: the key difference



The most useful way to think about it is this:

- **Desktop** is the **creation environment**
- **Service** is the **distribution and management environment**

Desktop is focused on building the report and the data model. Service is focused on making that report available to others, keeping it updated, and controlling how it's accessed.

When should marketing teams use each one?

Power BI Desktop	Power BI Service
Create or update reports	Share dashboards with leadership and other teams
Connect new data sources (GA4, Meta Ads, CRM exports)	Ensure everyone works from the same source of truth
Improve data quality or fix transformations	Automate data refresh so reports stay up to date
Adjust KPI definitions (ROAS, CAC, conversion rate)	Manage access for internal teams, agencies, or regions
Add pages, visuals, or new breakdowns (channel, country, campaign)	Operationalize reporting at scale

In practice, Desktop and Service are not competing products. They are two parts of a single workflow.

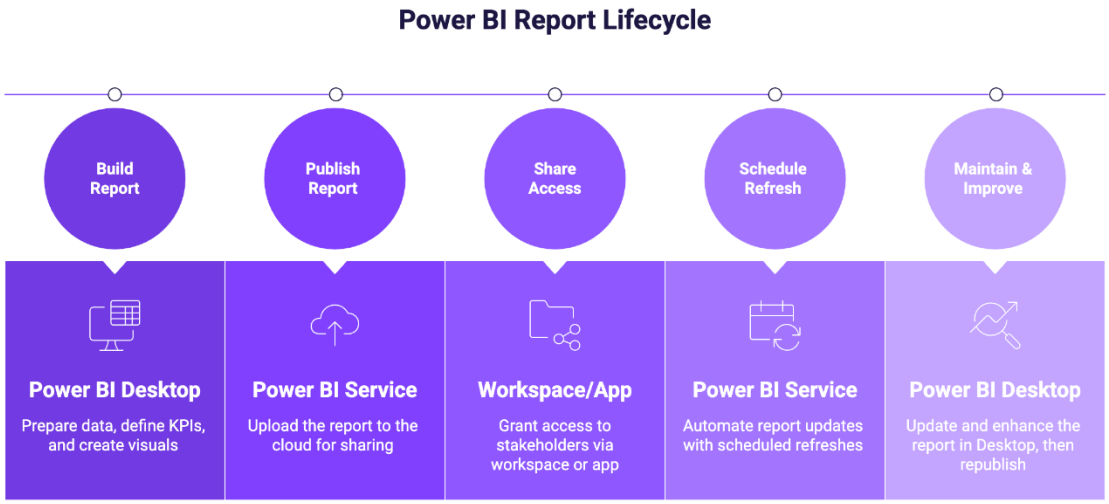
Reports, datasets, and dashboards: what lives where?

These terms are often confusing at first, but they become simple once you know what each one means.

- A **dataset** is the foundation: it contains the data model, relationships, and KPIs.
- A **report** is what you build on top of a dataset: a set of interactive pages with visuals.
- A **dashboard** is a curated view in Power BI Service: it pins key visuals (tiles) from one or more reports.

Where they live:

- In **Power BI Desktop**, you create the dataset and the report inside a PBIX file.
- In **Power BI Service**, you can manage datasets and reports after publishing, and you can create dashboards.



For marketers, the practical takeaway is that you build in Desktop, then you publish to the Service so the rest of the organization can access the reporting.

So, what should you use?

In most marketing teams, reports are built in **Power BI Desktop**, then published to **Power BI Service** to share dashboards, manage access, and automate refresh. If you're just starting out, begin with Desktop since it's free and perfect for learning the fundamentals, then switch to the Service as soon as you need collaboration, sharing, or automated updates. In practice, teams rarely choose one over the other, they typically use both.

Power BI explained for Marketing Teams

Power BI is a business intelligence tool used by marketing teams to analyze campaigns, funnels, and performance data. Learn what Power BI is, how marketers use it, and what dashboards you can build.



Power BI is a business intelligence tool developed by Microsoft. It's widely used across many teams, including Marketing, to create clear, professional dashboards and reports. Power BI helps teams visualize and analyze key metrics, uncover insights, and make data-driven decisions.

In this article, you'll learn:

- what Power BI is (in simple terms)
- how marketers use it
- who uses it in a marketing organization
- real examples of dashboards

What is Power BI? – Definition

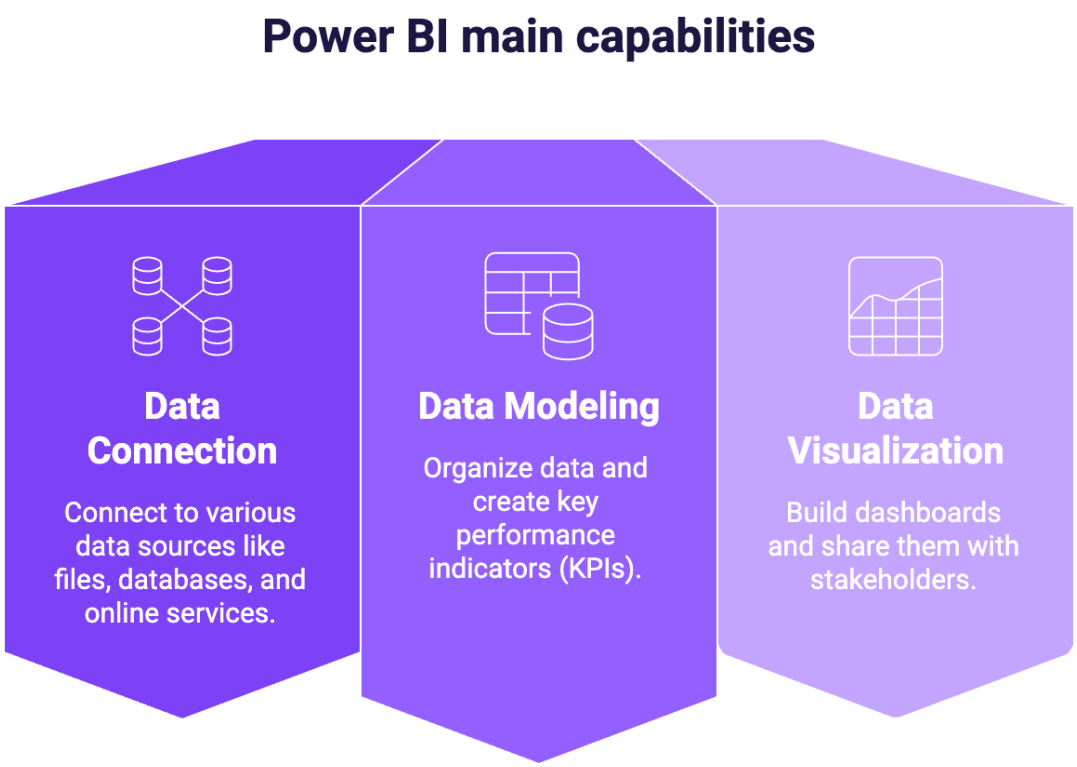
Power BI is a **business intelligence (BI) platform** created by Microsoft that allows teams to **collect, model, analyze, and visualize data** in the form of interactive reports and dashboards.

At its core, Power BI helps transform **raw data** (tables, exports, databases, APIs) into **structured insights** that can be explored visually. Instead of working with static spreadsheets, users interact with charts, tables, filters, and drill-downs to understand what is happening in their data and why.

Power BI is built around three main capabilities:

- **Data connection**: connect to many types of data sources (files, databases, online services)

- **Data modeling & calculations**: organize data and create metrics (KPIs)
- **Data visualization & sharing**: build dashboards and share them with stakeholders



Power BI is part of the **Microsoft ecosystem**, alongside tools like Excel, Azure, and Microsoft 365, but it is designed for **analytics and reporting at scale**, not just individual analysis.

Importantly, Power BI does **not create data on its own**. It relies on existing data sources and focuses on making that data **usable, understandable, and actionable** through reporting and visualization.

In the context of marketing, this means Power BI acts as the layer where data from advertising platforms, analytics tools, and CRMs can be analyzed together to support better decisions.

Power BI for Marketing

Now, let's focus on Power BI for Marketing.

What is Power BI used for in Marketing

Marketing teams use Power BI to **analyze performance across channels, campaigns, and the entire customer journey**. Its main role is to bring clarity to fragmented

marketing data and turn it into actionable insights. In practice, Power BI is commonly used for:

Campaign performance tracking

Monitor spend, impressions, clicks, conversions, and revenue across paid media platforms. Power BI makes it easy to compare campaigns, identify top performers, and detect underperforming initiatives.

Channel and mix analysis

Analyze performance by channel (Paid Search, Paid Social, Email, Organic, etc.) to understand where budget is most effective and how channels contribute to overall results.

Funnel and conversion analysis

Track how users move from acquisition to conversion, whether it's visits → leads → customers in B2C, or Ads → Leads → Opportunities → Deals in B2B.

Budget pacing and performance monitoring

Follow spend versus targets over time and ensure campaigns are on track before the end of the month or quarter.

Recurring reporting and executive dashboards

Replace manual weekly or monthly reports with automated dashboards that update regularly and provide a shared source of truth.

Power BI is especially valuable when marketing teams need to **combine data from multiple tools** and analyze trends over time rather than look at isolated platform reports.

Who uses Power BI in Marketing teams

Power BI can be used by different roles within a marketing organization, each with a different level of involvement.

- **Performance and acquisition marketers:** Use Power BI to monitor campaign results, compare channels, and optimize spend based on KPIs such as CPA, ROAS, or conversion rate.
- **Marketing analysts and operations teams:** Design data models, define KPIs, and build dashboards that standardize reporting across teams and regions.
- **Growth and lifecycle teams:** Analyze user behavior across touchpoints, cohorts, and retention metrics to understand long-term performance beyond first conversion.

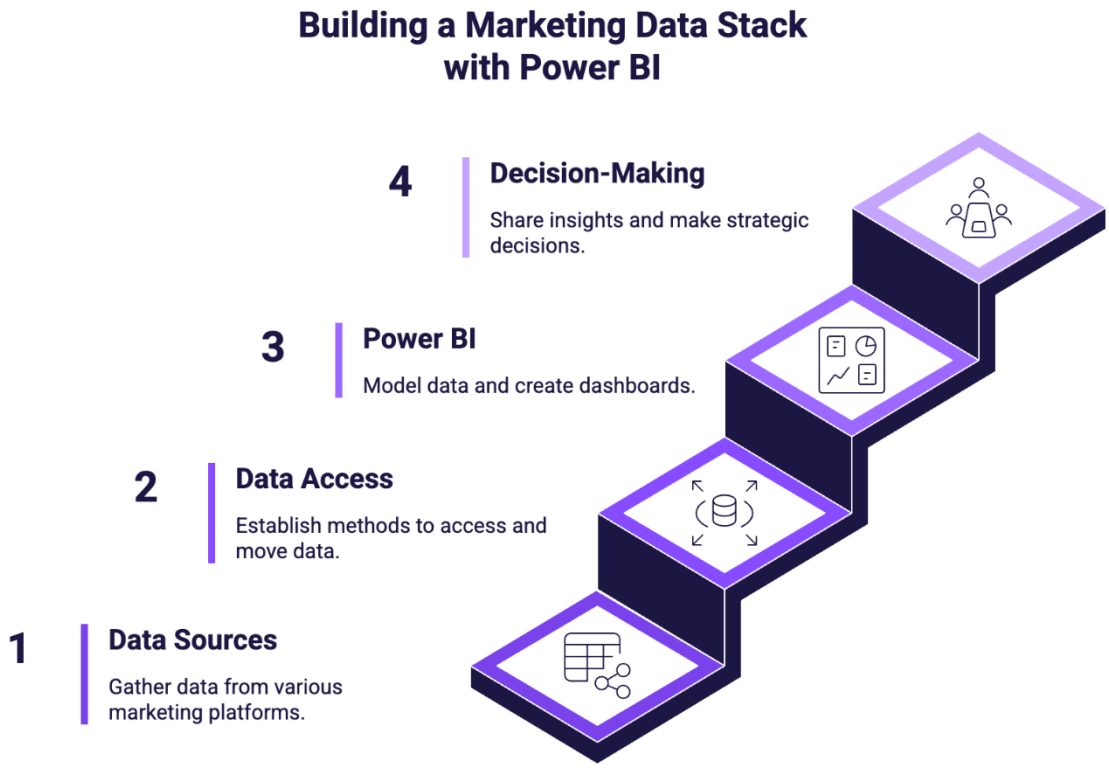
- **Marketing leadership (CMOs, Heads of Marketing):** Consume dashboards to track high-level performance, trends, and progress toward objectives, without needing to build reports themselves.
- **Agencies and consultants:** Use Power BI to manage multi-client reporting and deliver standardized dashboards to their customers.

In most organizations, a small number of people build reports, while many stakeholders consume them, which is one of the strengths of Power BI as a shared reporting platform.

Where Power BI fits in Marketing data stack

Power BI sits at the **analysis and visualization layer** of the marketing data stack.

It does not replace marketing platforms, analytics tools, or CRMs. Instead, it connects to them and transforms their data into insights.



A simplified marketing data stack looks like this:

1. **Data sources:** Advertising platforms, web analytics tools, email platforms, CRMs, and internal data.

2. **Data access and movement:** Data can be accessed via exports, APIs, connectors, or data warehouses, depending on the level of automation and scale needed.
3. **Power BI:** Used to model data, calculate KPIs, and build dashboards and reports.
4. **Decision-making and reporting:** Dashboards are shared with teams and stakeholders to support daily optimization and strategic decisions.

In this setup, Power BI acts as the **central reporting layer**, where marketing data is unified, standardized, and made accessible to non-technical users.

Is Power BI a good choice for Marketing?

Power BI is a strong option for marketing teams that need **flexible, scalable, and reliable reporting**, especially when working with multiple data sources.

When Power BI is a good fit for marketing teams	Considerations to keep in mind
Marketing data comes from several platforms (ads, analytics, CRM, email) and needs to be analyzed together	Power BI requires clean and well-structured data to deliver reliable insights
Reporting needs to be automated and shared with multiple stakeholders	There is a learning curve, particularly around data modeling and KPI definitions
KPIs must be consistent across teams, regions, or channels	Automation depends on how data is connected and refreshed
Analysis goes beyond basic platform dashboards and requires deeper exploration	Initial setup takes more effort than using native reporting tools

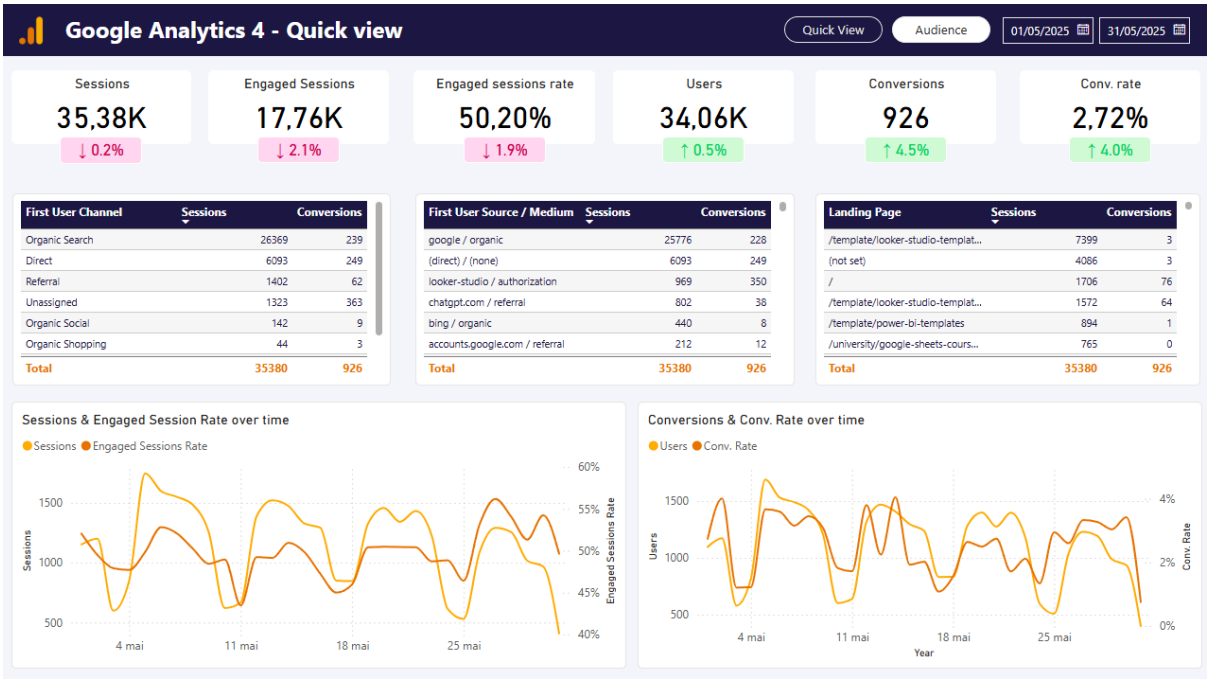
For many marketing teams, Power BI becomes most valuable once they move beyond spreadsheets and platform-native reports and need a **single source of truth** for performance analysis.

When implemented with the right data setup and clear KPIs, Power BI can support both **day-to-day optimization and strategic marketing decisions**.

Typical Marketing dashboards you can build with Power BI

Power BI lets marketing teams build dashboards that range from platform-specific monitoring to cross-channel performance reporting. Here are the most common ones to start with.

GA4 performance dashboard (Website & conversion tracking)



Use this dashboard to understand how your site is performing and how users convert.

You typically track sessions, users, engagement metrics, key events, and conversions, with filters such as date range, channel group, country, device, landing page, or campaign.

[Get this GA4 dashboard template for Power BI]

Meta Ads dashboard (Paid social performance)

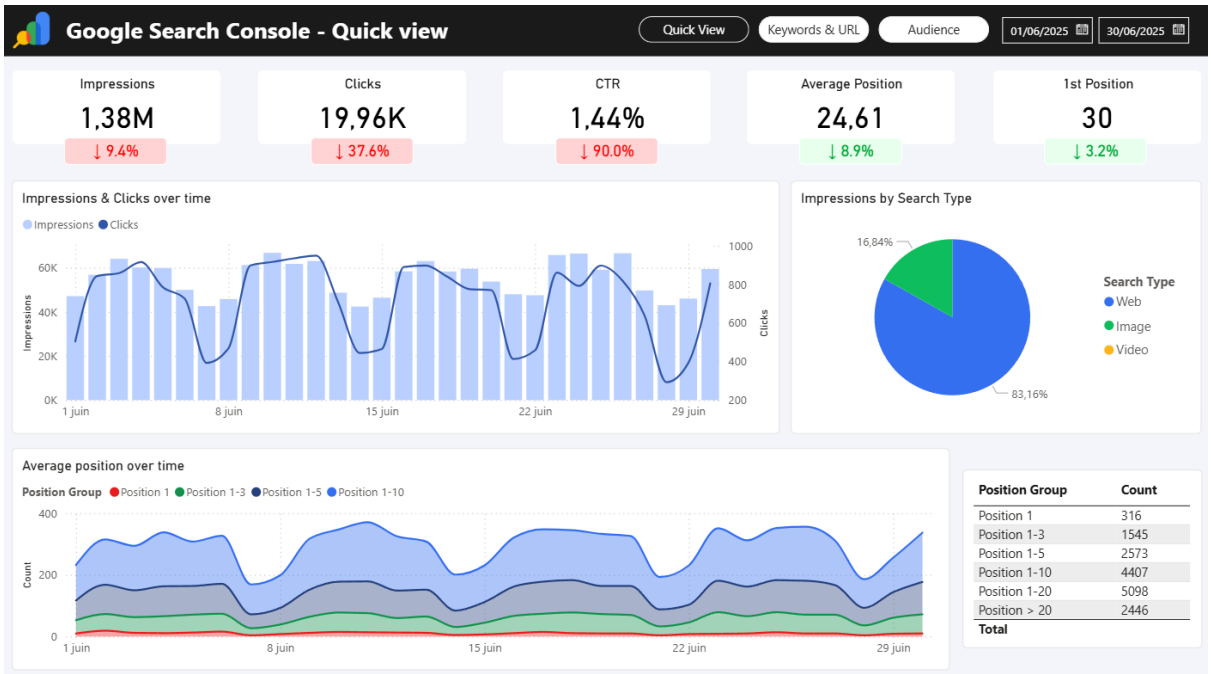


This dashboard focuses on campaign efficiency and budget optimization.

It usually includes spend, impressions, reach, clicks, results, and KPIs like CPM, CPC, CTR, CPA, and ROAS, with drill-down from campaign to ad set to ad to quickly identify what's driving performance.

[Get this Meta Ads dashboard template for Power BI]

Google Search Console dashboard (SEO performance)



This dashboard helps you monitor organic search visibility and identify growth opportunities.

Common metrics include clicks, impressions, CTR, and average position, segmented by query, page, country, device, and search type, with period comparisons to spot changes over time.

Get this Google Search dashboard template for Power BI

Cross-channel marketing performance dashboard (The "single view")

Once you have a few sources, many teams build a unified dashboard to compare channels side by side and understand what's driving results.

Typical views include spend vs outcomes by channel, CAC/ROAS by channel, and performance trends across Paid Search, Paid Social, SEO, and Email.

Executive marketing dashboard (Leadership reporting)

Designed for stakeholders who want a clear summary, not operational details.

It usually includes a KPI snapshot, key trends, highlights and drivers, plus a short section for insights and recommended actions.

What you need to get started with Power BI?

Getting started with Power BI does not require advanced technical skills, but a few fundamentals make the process much smoother:

- **Access to your marketing data**, whether it comes from advertising platforms, analytics tools, a CRM, or simple Excel or CSV exports
- **Clearly defined KPIs**, as Power BI is most effective when metrics such as conversions, CPA, or ROAS are well understood upfront
- **Power BI Desktop**, which is sufficient to start building reports and is available for free
- **Time to learn the basics**, such as data structure, filters, and measures, which allows marketers to become productive without a data background

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Can Power BI replace Google Sheets for reporting?

Power BI does not replace Google Sheets entirely, but it often replaces spreadsheets for recurring and shared reporting. While spreadsheets remain useful for ad hoc analysis and quick calculations, Power BI is better suited for automated dashboards, consistent KPI definitions, and reports that need to scale across teams.

Is Power BI suitable for small marketing teams?

Yes, Power BI can work well for small marketing teams, particularly when reporting needs grow beyond manual spreadsheets. Teams can start with simple dashboards and add complexity over time as data volume and reporting requirements increase.

Can Power BI connect to marketing platforms?

Power BI can connect to marketing platforms in different ways, including manual file exports, direct APIs, dedicated connectors such as Catchr.io, or a data warehouse. The right approach depends on the level of automation and scale you need, but in most cases, marketing data from common platforms can be brought into Power BI and analyzed in a consistent reporting model.

Is Power BI better than Looker Studio for marketing?

Power BI and Looker Studio serve similar purposes but differ in depth and flexibility. Looker Studio is often easier to start with and works well for lightweight reporting, while Power BI offers more advanced data modeling, calculations, and scalability, which can be valuable for growing or more complex marketing teams.

What's next?

Now that you understand what Power BI is and how it can be used for marketing, you can move on to the next lessons. In this Power BI learning path, we'll cover the fundamentals, walk through the first steps of data modeling, show how to build and share dashboards, and introduce the basics of DAX formulas.

Power BI file types & project organization: Guide

Learn what PBIX files, PBIT templates, and datasets are in Power BI, and how marketing teams should organize reporting projects effectively.

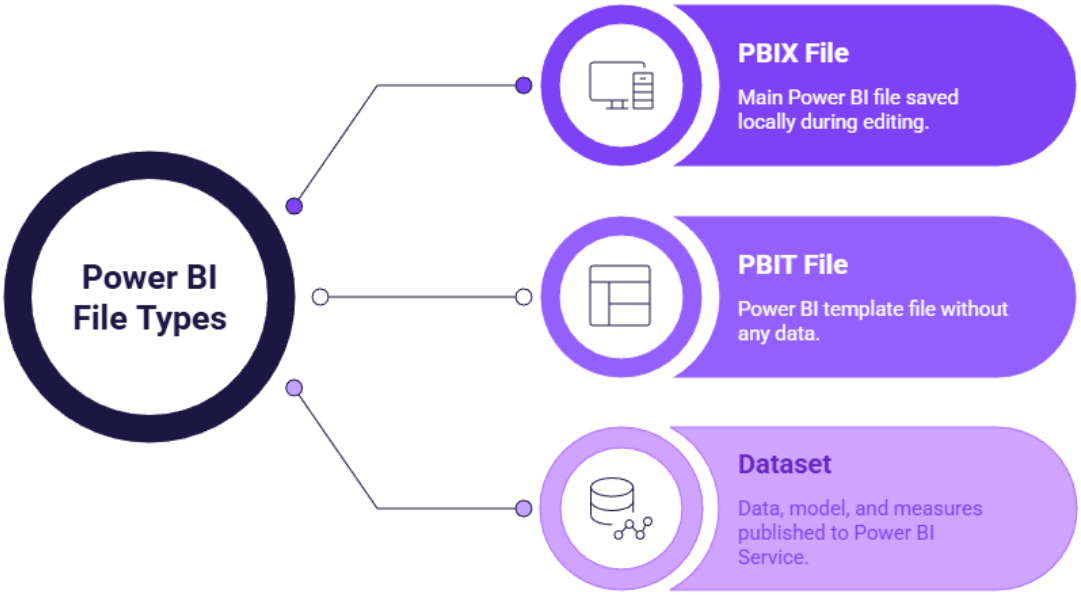


As you start building more reports in Power BI, questions naturally arise around files, reuse, and organization. What exactly is a PBIX file? How is it different from a template? What happens when you publish a report? And how should marketing teams organize their Power BI projects over time?

Understanding these basics early helps you avoid confusion, duplicated work, and messy reporting setups. In this article, we'll explain the main Power BI file types and share simple best practices to organize marketing reporting projects efficiently.

Power BI file types available

Power BI relies on a few key file types and objects. Each one plays a specific role in how reports are built, shared, and reused.



What is a PBIX file in Power BI?

A **PBIX** file is the main Power BI file you work with in Power BI Desktop. This is the file you save locally while building or editing a report.

A PBIX file contains:

- Data connections
- The data model and relationships
- Measures and calculations
- Report pages, visuals, and layout

For marketing teams, the PBIX file is the **working file**. It's where dashboards are created, updated, and maintained before being shared. Any change to visuals, KPIs, or structure happens inside this file.

What is a PBIT template in Power BI?

A **PBIT** file is a Power BI template. It looks similar to a PBIX file but does not include any data.

Templates keep:

- The report structure
- Visuals and layout

- Measures and calculations
- Data source definitions **(without the data itself)**

They are especially useful for marketing teams that need to reuse the same dashboard structure across multiple accounts, countries, or platforms. For example, a Meta Ads performance dashboard or a ecommerce reporting template can be reused without starting from scratch each time.

Templates help standardize reporting while keeping flexibility.

What is a dataset in Power BI?

A **dataset** is created when a PBIX file is published to Power BI Service. It contains the data, the data model, and all measures defined in the report.

From a marketing perspective, the dataset acts as the **engine behind your dashboards**. One dataset can power multiple reports, ensuring that KPIs and definitions remain consistent across teams or regions.

Beginners often don't see datasets directly, but understanding their role is important as reporting becomes more collaborative and scalable.

How these elements work together

In practice, marketing teams usually follow a simple flow. A PBIX file is used locally to build and update a report. When the report is published, Power BI Service creates a dataset from it. Other reports can then connect to that dataset, and PBIT templates can be used to replicate the same structure for new use cases.



This separation between files, templates, and datasets is what makes Power BI scalable over time.

Organizing Power BI projects for marketing teams

Beyond file types, good organization habits are essential to keep reporting manageable as the number of dashboards grows.

Naming conventions for Power BI files

Clear naming conventions make reports easier to find and understand. A good practice is to include the marketing channel or use case first, followed by the scope or purpose.

Examples:

- SEO_GSC_Performance.pbix
- PaidAds_Global_Dashboard.pbix
- CRM_Leads_Template.pbit

Avoid adding dates or version numbers directly in file names unless necessary. This keeps filenames stable and easier to reuse.

Folder structure for marketing reporting

A simple folder structure helps separate working files from reusable assets. Many marketing teams use a structure similar to this:

- PowerBI
    - Templates
    - Production
    - Archive
    - Exports

Templates are stored separately, production files are actively maintained, archives keep old versions, and raw exports are isolated from reporting files.

Versioning and collaboration tips

To avoid confusion, it's best to assign a clear owner to each report. Before making major changes, duplicate the PBIX file instead of editing the production version directly. Avoid vague file names like "final_v3_last.pbix" and keep changes documented lightly when working as a team.

These simple habits prevent accidental overwrites and broken dashboards.

Common mistakes

A common mistake is creating a new PBIX file for every reporting period instead of reusing the same report. Others duplicate reports endlessly instead of using templates, or mix raw data exports with reporting files.

Another frequent issue is editing production files directly without backups, which can lead to lost work. Most of these problems come from unclear file organization rather than Power BI itself.

Key takeaways

Understanding Power BI file types and organizing your projects properly helps keep marketing reporting clear, reusable, and easy to maintain. By knowing when to use PBIX files, templates, and datasets, and by applying simple naming and folder rules, you reduce duplication, avoid mistakes, and make dashboards easier to scale as reporting needs grow.

Connect data to Power BI: Guide

Learn how to connect marketing data to Power BI, choose between Import and DirectQuery, and decide when to use files, online services, or connectors.

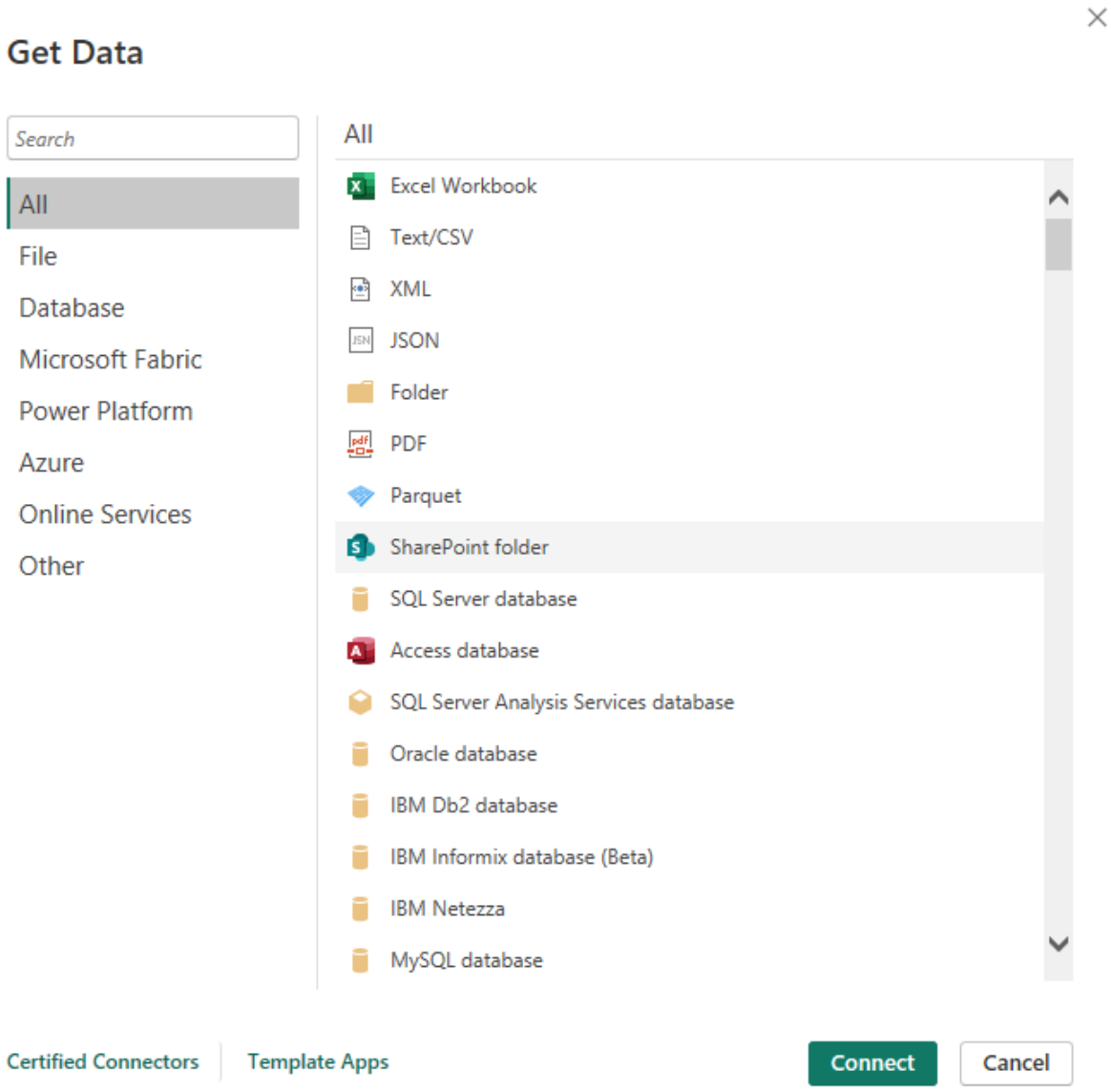


Before you can do anything in Power BI, you need to bring data into your report. There are many ways to do this, sometimes manually through exports and imports, and sometimes automatically using online services, APIs, or connectors.

In this lesson, we'll focus on the most essential and commonly used ways for marketing teams to connect their data to Power BI. We'll also explain how to choose between Import and DirectQuery, and share high-level best practices to avoid common issues.

How to get data in Power BI

When you click **Get data** in Power BI Desktop, you'll see that data sources are grouped into **seven main categories**. You can connect data from **files and folders**, **databases**, **Microsoft Fabric**, **Power Platform**, **Azure services**, **online services**, and **other sources**, including web-based connections.



While Power BI offers many technical options, most marketing reporting setups rely on a much smaller subset of these sources.

Main ways to get data in Power BI

In practice, the most common ways to feed a Power BI report in a marketing context are the following:

- Import data from a **CSV export**
- Import data from an **Excel export**
- Connect to an **online service or API**
- Use a **connector** to automate data collection and refresh

Each method has its advantages and answers different needs in terms of automation, data freshness, and scalability.

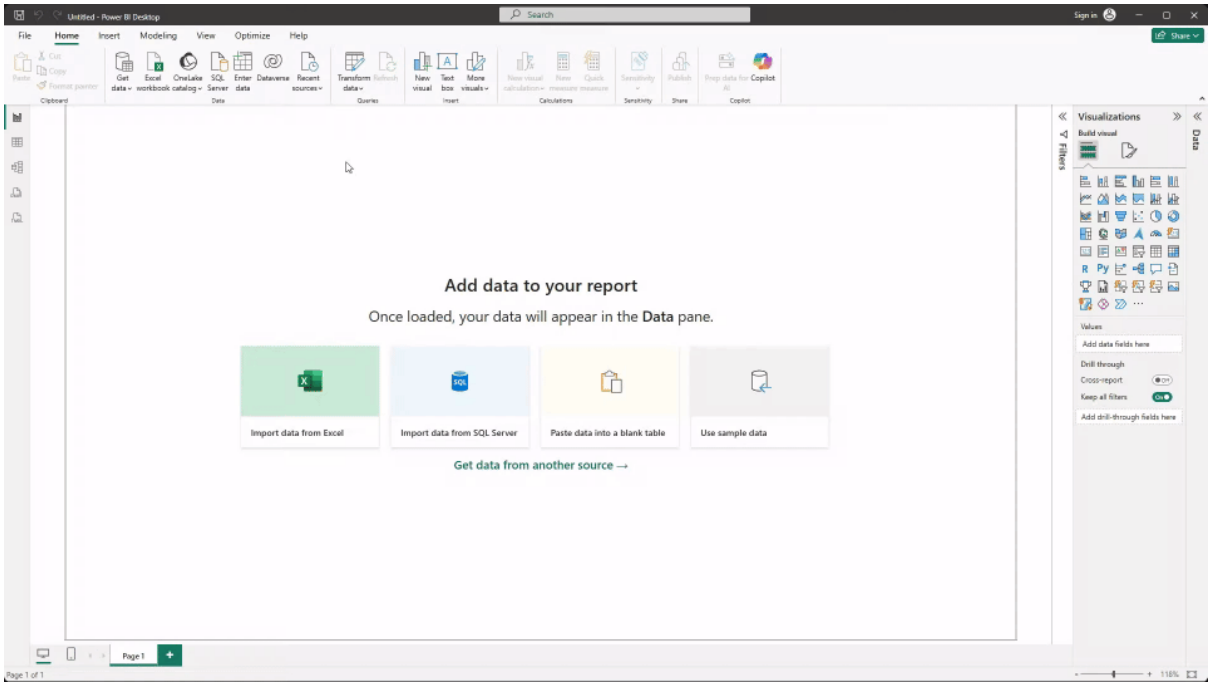
Importing data from CSV or Excel files

CSV and Excel files are often the starting point for marketing teams. Data exported from platforms such as Meta Ads, Shopify, analytics tools, advertising platforms, or CRMs can be loaded directly into Power BI.

This approach is easy to set up and works well for learning, testing, or small reporting needs. It gives full flexibility when building dashboards, but it relies on manual updates and becomes harder to maintain as reporting grows.

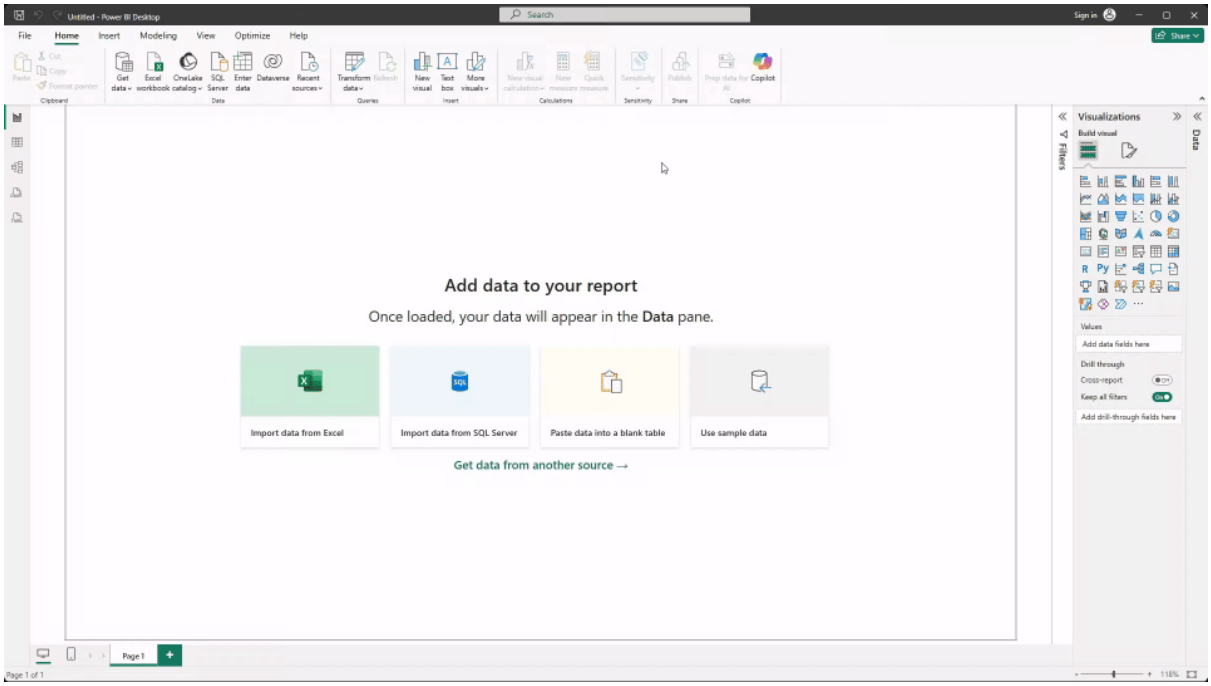
Data from a CSV to Power BI

1. Click **Get Data**.
2. Select **Text/CSV**.
3. Choose your file and click **Load** to import the data.



Data from Excel to Power BI

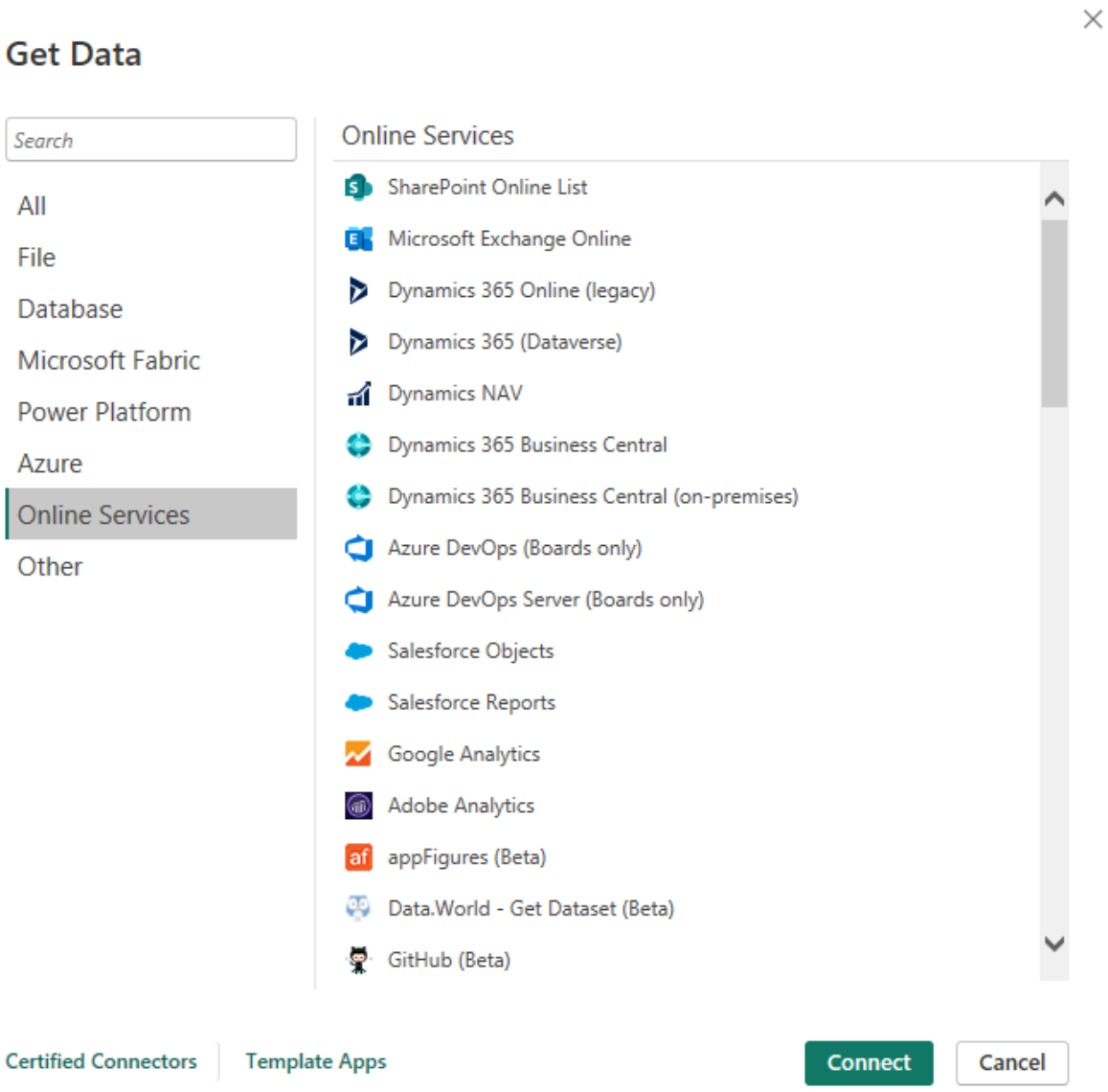
1. Click **Get Data**.
2. Select **Excel Workbook**.
3. Choose your file and click **Load** to import the data.



Connecting to online services and APIs

Power BI also allows you to connect directly to certain online services. These connections reduce manual work by pulling data from the source without exporting files.

1. Click **Get Data**.
2. Select **Online Services** tab.
3. Choose your service and follow the instructions in Power BI.



For marketing teams, this can be useful when supported services match reporting needs. However, availability and limitations vary depending on the platform, and this approach still requires monitoring and maintenance.

Using connectors to automate marketing data

Connectors are designed to simplify data access by handling authentication, extraction, and refresh automatically. Instead of managing exports or API logic, marketers can focus on analysis and dashboards.

This approach is especially useful when working with multiple platforms, recurring reports, or shared dashboards. Connectors help standardize data structures and ensure data stays up to date.

Catchr is one of the connector you can use to get Marketing data into Power BI.

Which method should you choose to get data in Power BI

To choose the best method for your needs, we'll base the decision on your report's primary use case, the level of automation required, and how fresh and scalable the data needs to be, while also considering the limitations of each option and the setup effort involved.

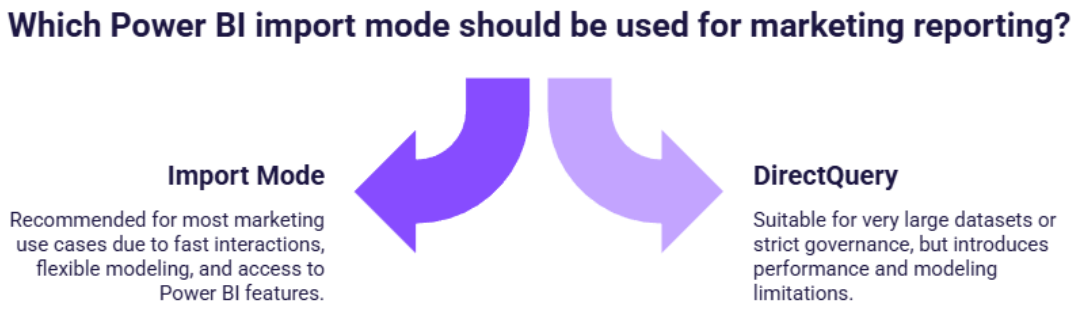
Method	Best for	Automation	Data freshness	Setup effort	Scalability	Typical limitations
CSV exports	Quick tests, small recurring reports, learning Power BI	Low (manual exports/imports)	Low to medium (depends on how often you re-export)	Very low	Low	Easy to break with changing columns, manual work grows fast, versioning issues
Excel files	Structured reporting, templates, teams already working in Excel	Low to medium (can be manual or semi-automated)	Low to medium	Low	Medium	File hygiene matters (formatting, headers, totals), can become messy at scale

Method	Best for	Automation	Data freshness	Setup effort	Scalability	Typical limitations
Online services / APIs	More automated pull from a platform when supported	Medium	Medium to high	Medium	Medium	Not all platforms supported, limitations vary, monitoring required
Connector (e.g., Catchr)	Multi-platform marketing reporting, shared dashboards, reliable refresh	High	High	Low to medium	High	Requires a connector tool/subscription, initial mapping/setup decisions

To get started, discover Power BI, and learn how to use it, we recommend working with CSV or Excel exports. Online services and connectors are better suited once you are comfortable with the tool and start using it on a daily basis.

Import vs DirectQuery in Power BI

When connecting data to Power BI, you also need to choose how the data is accessed. Power BI mainly offers two modes: **Import** and **DirectQuery**.



Import mode for marketing reporting

With Import mode, data is copied into Power BI and stored in the dataset. This allows fast interactions, flexible modeling, and access to most Power BI features.

For marketing teams, Import mode is the most common and recommended option. It works well with files, connectors, and many online services, and offers the best balance between performance and simplicity.

DirectQuery and when it makes sense

DirectQuery keeps data in the original source and queries it in real time. While this can be useful for very large datasets or strict governance requirements, it introduces limitations in performance and modeling.

For most marketing reporting use cases, DirectQuery adds complexity without clear benefits.

In practice, marketing teams should use **Import** mode in almost all cases. DirectQuery should only be considered when data volumes are extremely large or when data must remain live at all times.

Best practices to get data in Power BI

Choosing the right way to connect your data has a direct impact on how reliable and maintainable your Power BI reports will be over time. Most issues marketers encounter do not come from Power BI itself, but from how data is connected and prepared in the first place. Following a few best practices and avoiding common mistakes early on can save a lot of time later.

- Start with the simplest data source possible and scale your setup as reporting needs grow.
- Use **Import mode** in most marketing scenarios, as it offers better performance and flexibility than DirectQuery.

- Keep your data structure consistent over time, since changes in column names or formats often break existing visuals and KPIs.
- Make sure key fields such as dates and core metrics are correctly typed before building the report.
- Avoid mixing multiple exports with different structures unless they are standardized first.
- Fix data quality issues at the source whenever possible instead of compensating for them inside visuals.
- Do not rebuild reports from scratch when data changes; improve the data connection or refresh process instead.
- When reporting becomes recurring or involves multiple platforms, move away from manual exports and consider online services or connectors to keep dashboards up to date.

Conclusion

Connecting data to Power BI is a strategic decision, not just a technical one. Starting simple with file-based imports and Import mode is often the right approach for marketing teams, while automation through connectors becomes essential as reporting scales. Choosing the right connection method early makes Power BI reporting more reliable, efficient, and easier to maintain over time.

Connect Excel to Power BI: Guide

Learn how to use Excel with Power BI, prepare Power BI–friendly files, avoid common mistakes, and build reports that refresh without breaking.



Excel is one of the most common data sources for Power BI, especially for marketing teams, and it's often the easiest way to get started. Most issues, however, come from poorly structured Excel files. Formatting that works for presentations can break reporting once the file is used as a data source.

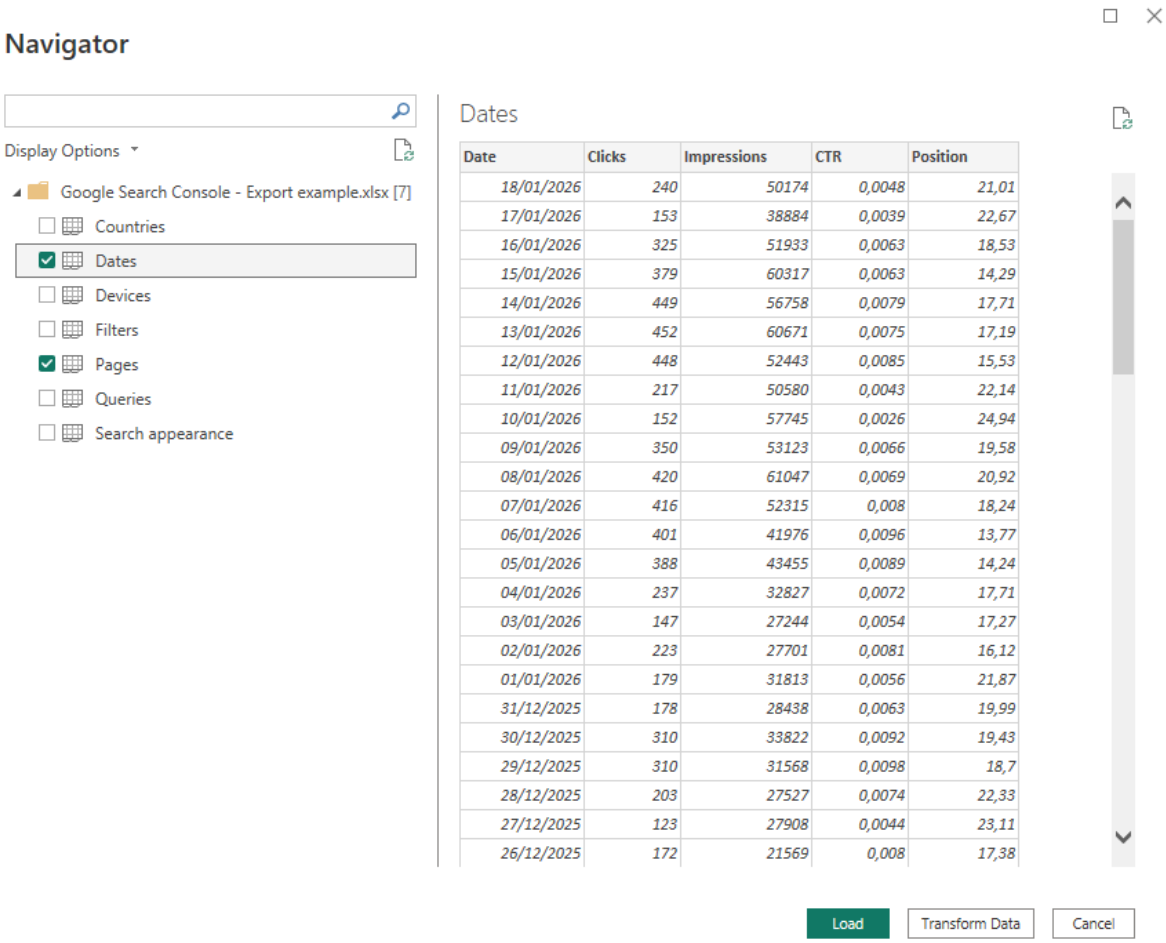
This article explains how to prepare a truly Power BI–friendly Excel file so your reports are easier to build, refresh, and maintain.

How Power BI works with Excel files

Before going into tutorial and best practices, it's important to understand how Power BI interprets an Excel file when you import it.

What happens when you import an Excel file

When you import an Excel file into Power BI, each worksheet is treated as a table. Power BI assumes that the **first row contains column headers**, and it automatically tries to detect data types for each column, such as dates, numbers, or text.



Date	Clicks	Impressions	CTR	Position
18/01/2026	240	50174	0,0048	21,01
17/01/2026	153	38884	0,0039	22,67
16/01/2026	325	51933	0,0063	18,53
15/01/2026	379	60317	0,0063	14,29
14/01/2026	449	56758	0,0079	17,71
13/01/2026	452	60671	0,0075	17,19
12/01/2026	448	52443	0,0085	15,53
11/01/2026	217	50580	0,0043	22,14
10/01/2026	152	57745	0,0026	24,94
09/01/2026	350	53123	0,0066	19,58
08/01/2026	420	61047	0,0069	20,92
07/01/2026	416	52315	0,008	18,24
06/01/2026	401	41976	0,0096	13,77
05/01/2026	388	43455	0,0089	14,24
04/01/2026	237	32827	0,0072	17,71
03/01/2026	147	27244	0,0054	17,27
02/01/2026	223	27701	0,0081	16,12
01/01/2026	179	31813	0,0056	21,87
31/12/2025	178	28438	0,0063	19,99
30/12/2025	310	33822	0,0092	19,43
29/12/2025	310	31568	0,0098	18,7
28/12/2025	203	27527	0,0074	22,33
27/12/2025	123	27908	0,0044	23,11
26/12/2025	172	21569	0,008	17,38

Power BI does not read Excel formatting or layout logic. It focuses only on the underlying tabular structure. Understanding this behavior helps explain why some Excel files work well and others cause issues, even before any visuals are created.

Excel is not a report, it's a data source

This is a key mindset shift. An Excel file used in Power BI should be treated as a **data source**, not as a presentation or report.

This means:

- No visual formatting
- No totals or subtotals inside the dataset
- No layout or storytelling logic in the file itself

Excel reports designed for human reading often conflict with how Power BI expects data to be structured. Once you start thinking of Excel as raw input rather than a final output, many common problems disappear.

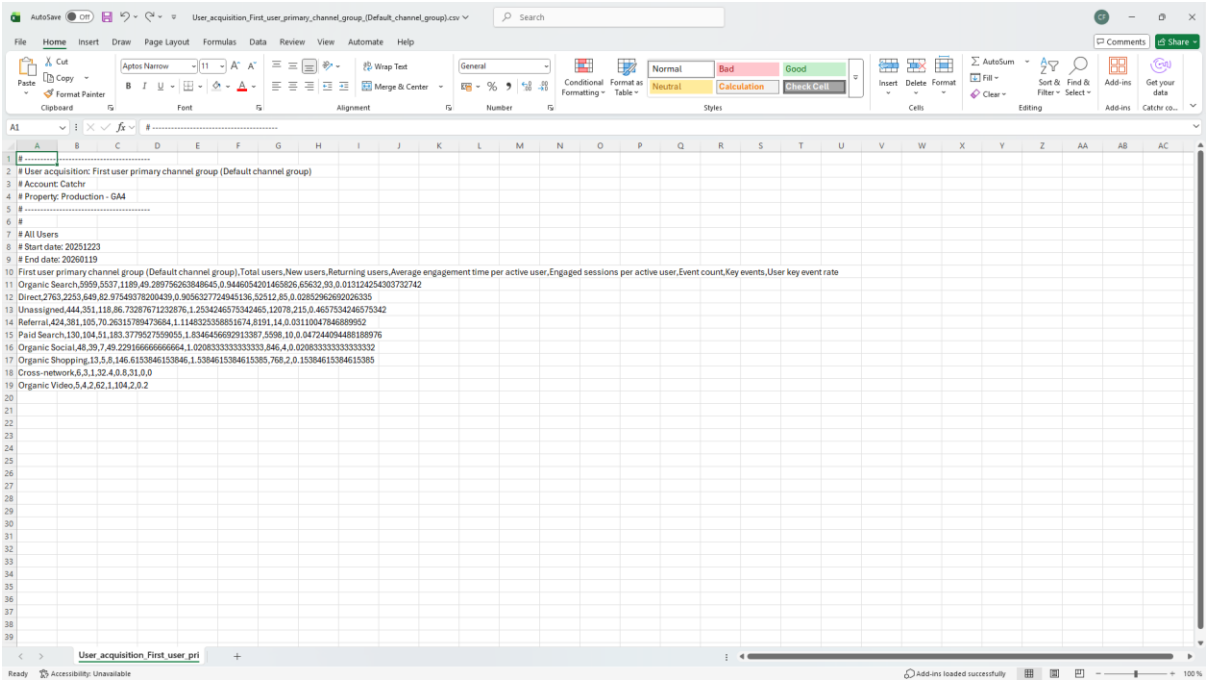
Step-by-step: from an Excel export to a Power BI report

This step-by-step guide shows how to go from a typical marketing export to a clean Excel file ready for Power BI.

Step 1: Start from a raw export

Always begin with a raw export from your platform. The file should be flat, without subtotals, summary rows, or extra header lines. Each row should represent a single observation, such as a campaign on a given date or a page for a given period.

In this example, we'll download a **Google Analytics 4** export focused on **User Acquisition**, using the *First user primary channel group* dimension.



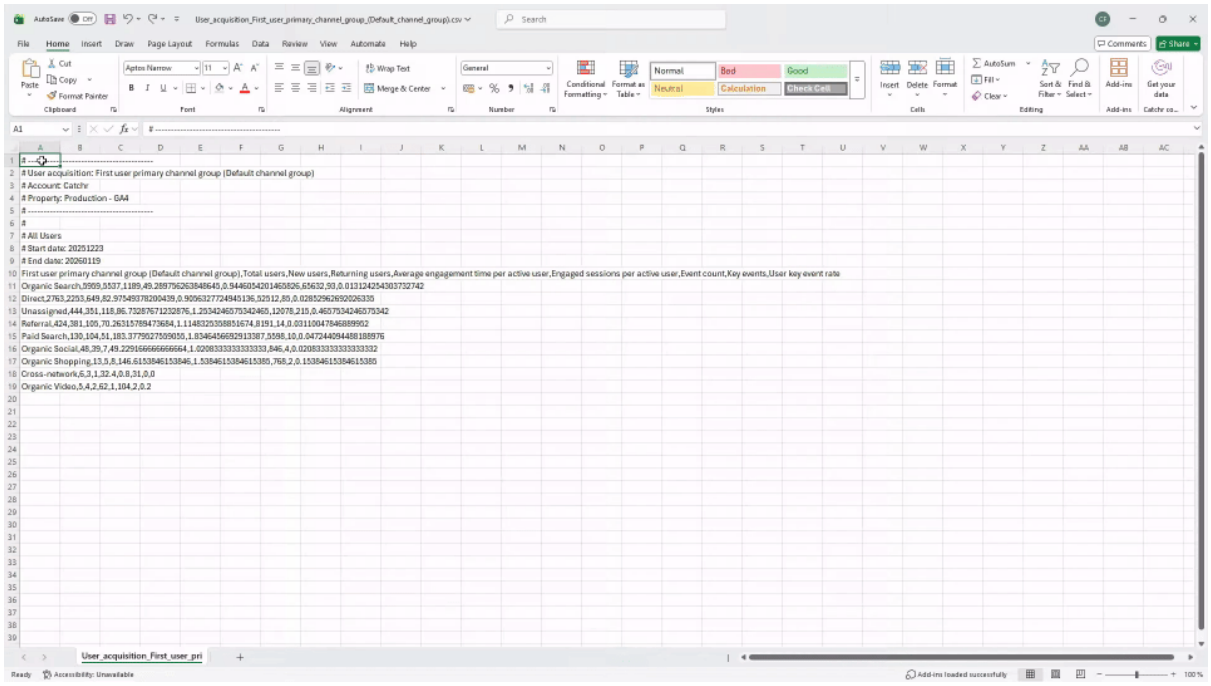
Some marketing platforms let you export data directly to Excel, but many only offer CSV exports. Excel files are usually easier to work with because they tend to be more structured, while CSV exports often require extra checks and cleanup before they are ready for Power BI. In this guide, we'll intentionally use a messier export so you can learn the essential cleaning steps.

Step 2: Turn it into a clean table structure

Your Excel file should follow a simple table structure:

- One header row at the top
- One column equals one field
- No merged cells
- No empty columns or rows inside the dataset

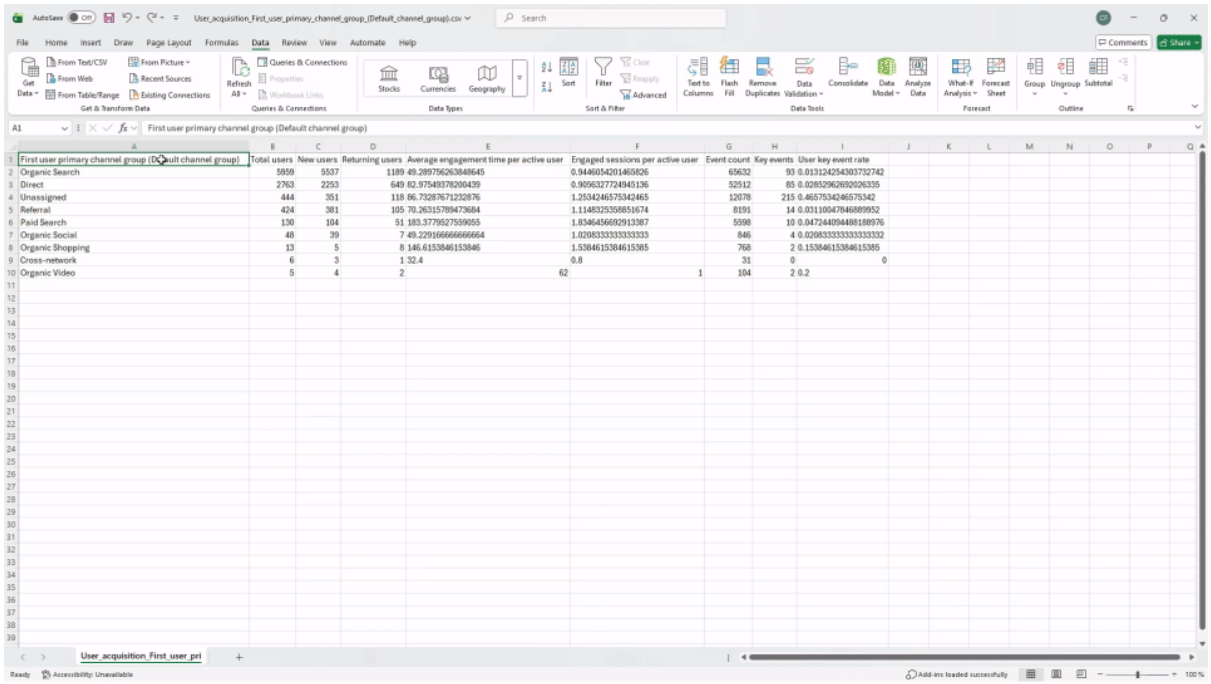
This structure allows Power BI to read the data reliably and consistently.



As a reminder, you can split a column into multiple columns using the Text to Columns feature in Excel. Go to Data > Text to Columns, choose the appropriate separator, and Excel will automatically split the values for you.

Step 3: Standardize names and formats

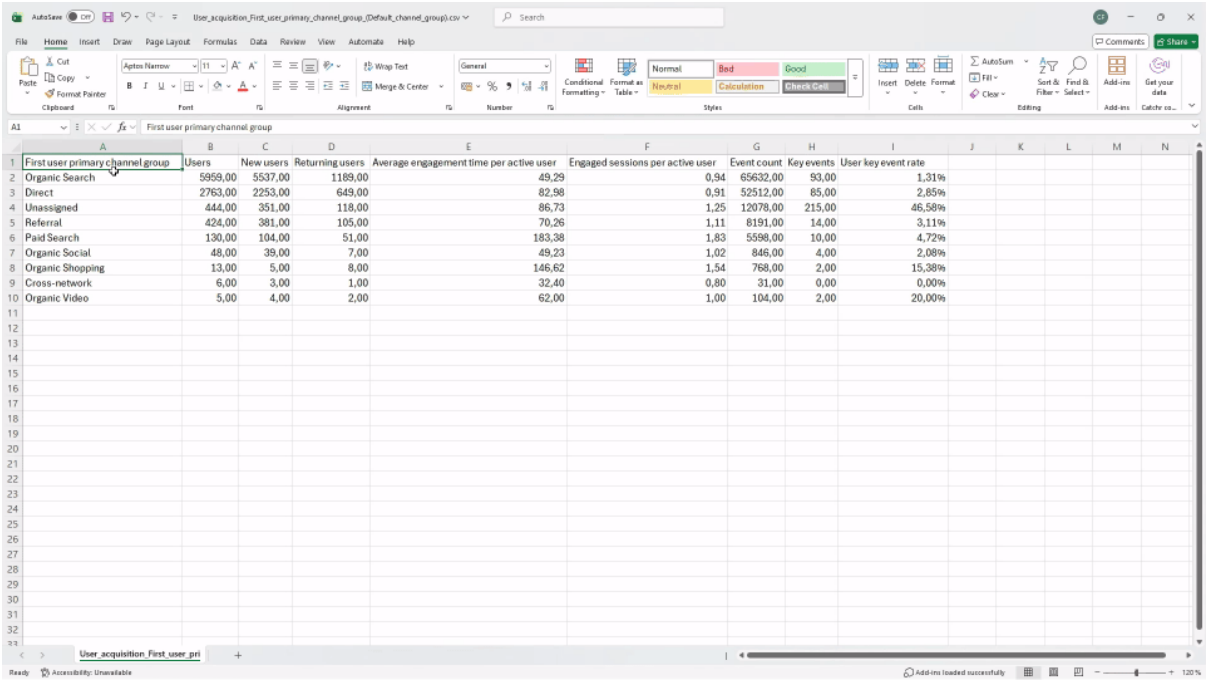
Column names should be stable and descriptive, but not verbose. Dates must be real date values, not text. Metrics should be numeric, and currencies or decimal formats should be consistent across the file.



Standardizing names and formats early prevents issues later when building visuals or refreshing data.

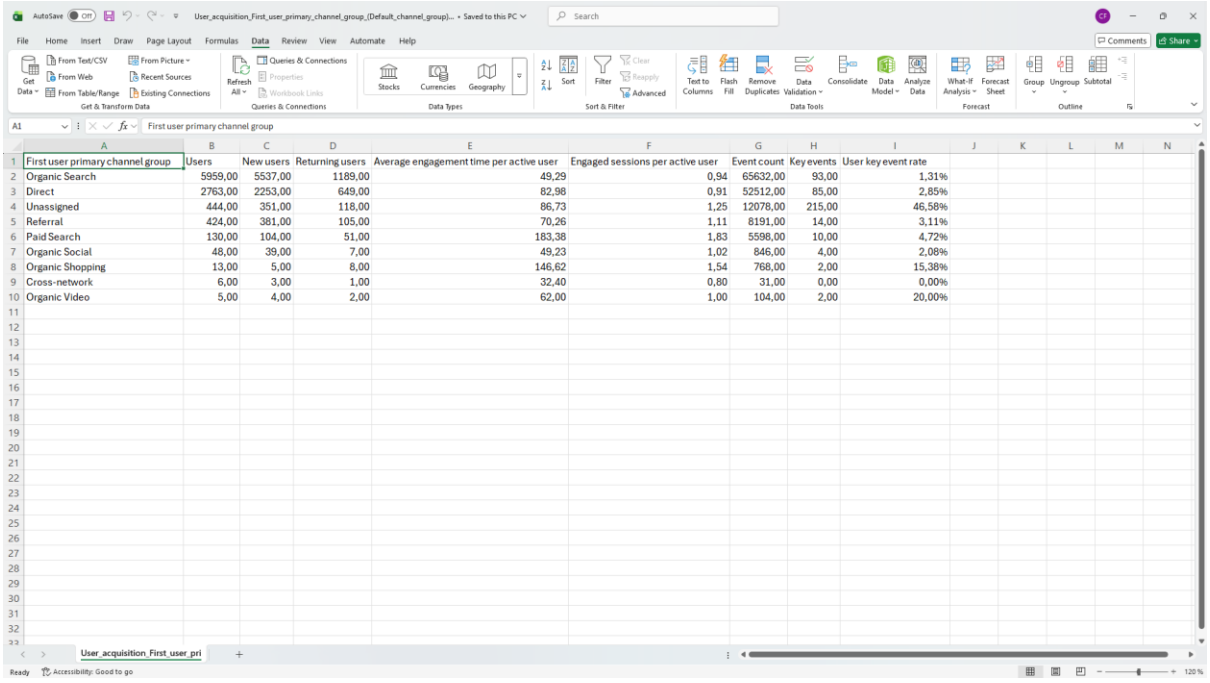
Step 4: Save the file properly

Save your file in .xlsx format. Ideally, each file should contain one dataset, or at least one clean table per sheet. Use a simple and consistent file naming convention so files are easy to identify over time.



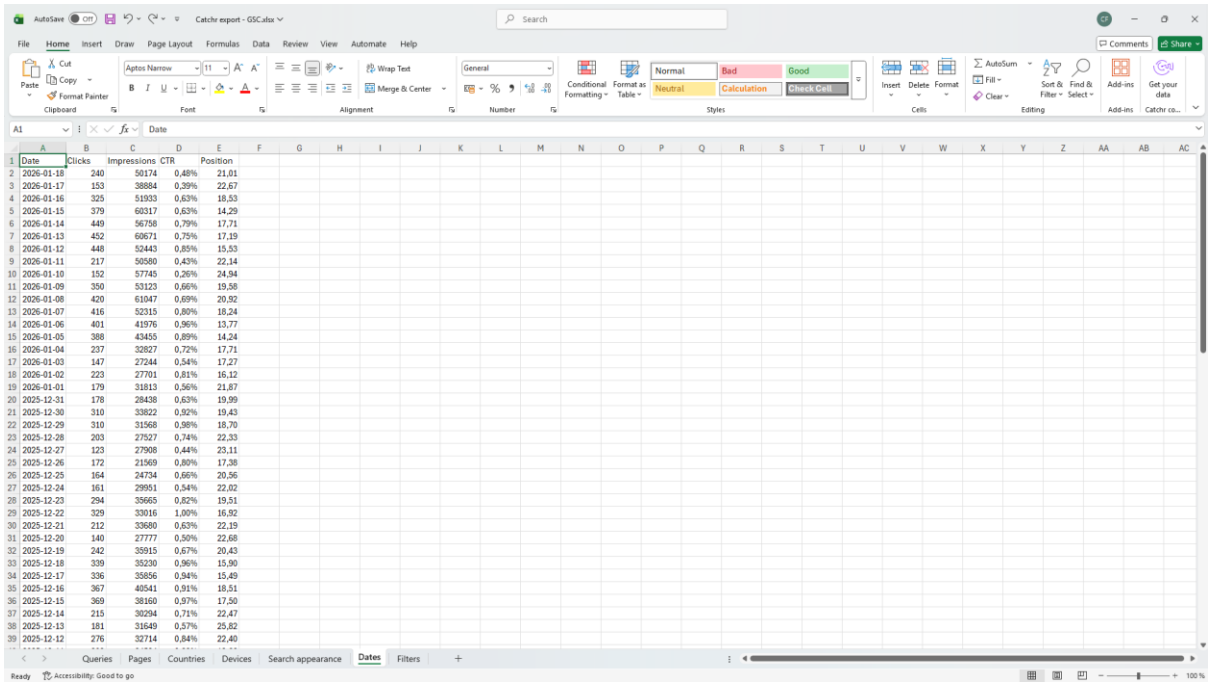
First user primary channel group	Users	New users	Returning users	Average engagement time per active user	Engaged sessions per active user	Event count	Key events	User key event rate
Organic Search	5959,00	5537,00	1189,00	49,29	0,94	65632,00	93,00	1,31%
Direct	2763,00	2253,00	649,00	82,98	0,91	52512,00	85,00	2,85%
Unassigned	444,00	351,00	118,00	86,73	1,25	12078,00	215,00	46,58%
Referral	424,00	381,00	105,00	70,26	1,11	8191,00	14,00	3,11%
Paid Search	130,00	104,00	51,00	183,38	1,83	5598,00	10,00	4,72%
Organic Social	48,00	39,00	7,00	49,23	1,02	846,00	4,00	2,08%
Organic Shopping	13,00	5,00	8,00	146,62	1,54	768,00	2,00	15,38%
Cross-network	6,00	3,00	1,00	32,40	0,80	31,00	0,00	0,00%
Organic Video	5,00	4,00	2,00	62,00	1,00	104,00	2,00	20,00%

File with one sheet



First user primary channel group	Users	New users	Returning users	Average engagement time per active user	Engaged sessions per active user	Event count	Key events	User key event rate
Organic Search	5959,00	5537,00	1189,00	49,29	0,94	65632,00	93,00	1,31%
Direct	2763,00	2253,00	649,00	82,98	0,91	52512,00	85,00	2,85%
Unassigned	444,00	351,00	118,00	86,73	1,25	12078,00	215,00	46,58%
Referral	424,00	381,00	105,00	70,26	1,11	8191,00	14,00	3,11%
Paid Search	130,00	104,00	51,00	183,38	1,83	5598,00	10,00	4,72%
Organic Social	48,00	39,00	7,00	49,23	1,02	846,00	4,00	2,08%
Organic Shopping	13,00	5,00	8,00	146,62	1,54	768,00	2,00	15,38%
Cross-network	6,00	3,00	1,00	32,40	0,80	31,00	0,00	0,00%
Organic Video	5,00	4,00	2,00	62,00	1,00	104,00	2,00	20,00%

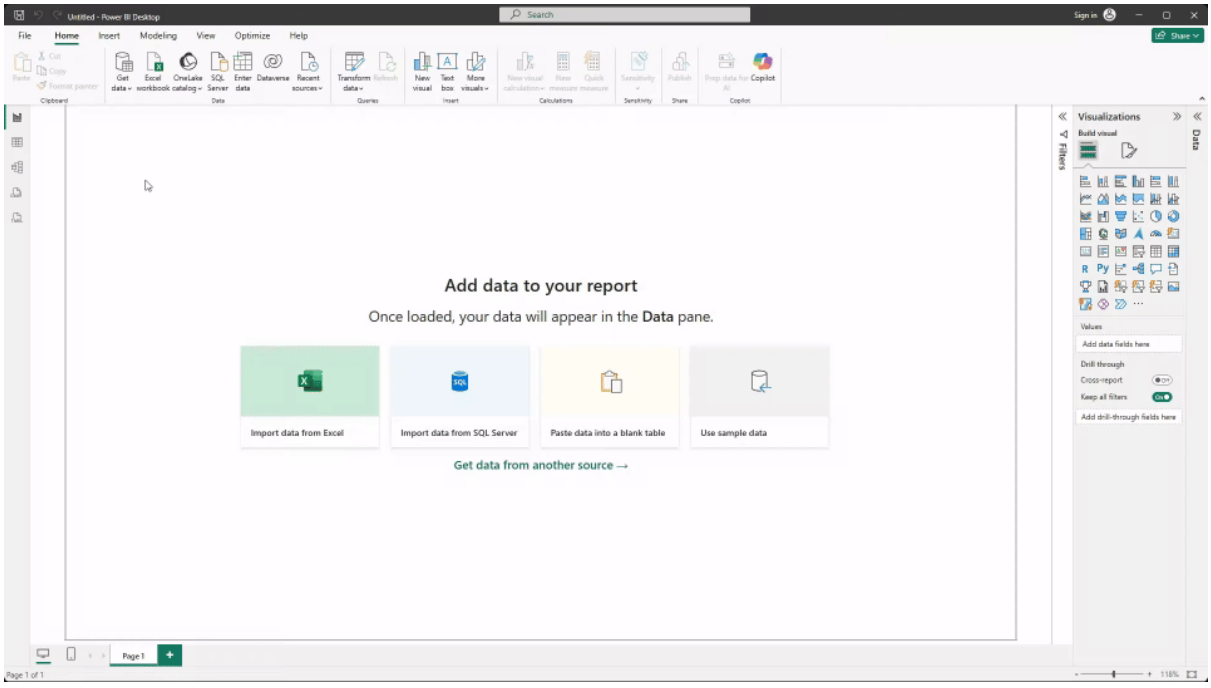
File with multiple sheets



Date	Clicks	Impressions	CTR	Position
2026-01-18	240	50174	0,48%	21,01
2026-01-17	153	38884	0,39%	22,67
2026-01-16	325	51933	0,63%	18,53
2026-01-15	379	60317	0,63%	14,29
2026-01-14	449	56758	0,79%	17,71
2026-01-13	452	60671	0,75%	17,19
2026-01-12	448	52443	0,85%	15,53
2026-01-11	217	50580	0,43%	22,14
2026-01-10	152	57745	0,26%	24,94
2026-01-09	350	53123	0,66%	19,58
2026-01-08	420	61047	0,69%	20,92
2026-01-07	416	52315	0,80%	18,24
2026-01-06	401	41976	0,96%	13,77
2026-01-05	388	43455	0,89%	14,24
2026-01-04	237	32827	0,72%	17,71
2026-01-03	147	27244	0,54%	17,27
2026-01-02	223	27701	0,81%	16,12
2026-01-01	179	31813	0,56%	21,87
2025-12-31	178	28438	0,63%	19,99
2025-12-30	310	33822	0,92%	19,43
2025-12-29	310	31568	0,98%	18,70
2025-12-28	203	27527	0,74%	22,33
2025-12-27	123	27908	0,44%	23,11
2025-12-26	172	21569	0,80%	17,38
2025-12-25	164	24734	0,66%	20,56
2025-12-24	161	29951	0,54%	22,02
2025-12-23	294	35665	0,82%	19,51
2025-12-22	329	33016	1,00%	16,92
2025-12-21	212	33680	0,63%	22,19
2025-12-20	140	27777	0,50%	22,68
2025-12-19	242	35915	0,67%	20,43
2025-12-18	339	35230	0,96%	15,90
2025-12-17	336	35856	0,94%	15,49
2025-12-16	367	40541	0,91%	18,51
2025-12-15	369	38160	0,97%	17,50
2025-12-14	215	30294	0,71%	22,47
2025-12-13	181	31649	0,57%	25,82
2025-12-12	276	32714	0,84%	22,40

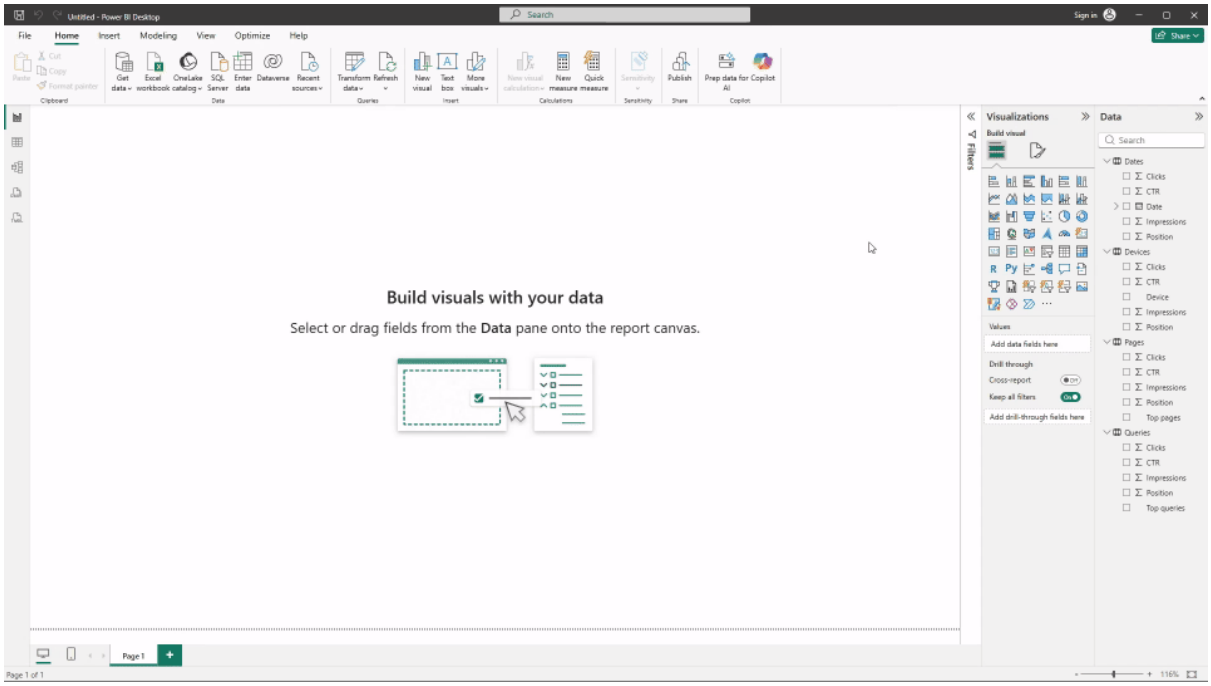
Step 5: Import into Power BI Desktop

In Power BI Desktop, click **Get data**, select **Excel**, choose your file, then select the relevant sheet or table. You can load the data directly, or open Transform data if minor adjustments are needed.



Step 6: Quick validation inside Power BI

Once the data is loaded, perform a quick check. Verify data types, scan a few values, and make sure the date field works correctly for filtering and time-based analysis. Catching issues at this stage saves time later.



Excel file checklist for Power BI reporting

Before importing an Excel (or CSV) file into Power BI, make sure that:

- The file contains **one clean table**, with **one header row** at the top.
- Headers are **not empty** and each column has a **clear, stable name**.
- The dataset is **raw and non-aggregated**, with **no totals, subtotals, or averages** inside the table.
- Each row represents **one observation** (for example one date, one campaign, one channel, one page).
- There are **no merged cells**, no extra titles, and no presentation formatting that breaks the table structure.
- There are **no blank rows or blank columns** inside the dataset.
- Dates are stored as **real dates**, not text, and numbers are stored as **real numeric values**.
- Column formats are consistent, especially for **currency, decimals, and separators**.
- The structure stays consistent across exports, with the same columns and naming, so refresh won't break.
- Column names are written for analysis, not presentation (for example clicks instead of Total Clicks (last 30 days)).

Refresh data from an Excel file in Power BI

When you click **Refresh** in **Power BI**, Power BI re-runs the entire data connection and reloads the Excel file from its source. This means that **all saved changes made in the Excel file**, such as updated values, new rows, or deleted data, are imported into the Power BI model at the time of the refresh.

For the refresh to work correctly, the Excel file must be **saved** and **accessible** to Power BI (local path, network drive, or cloud location). If the file is open but not saved, Power BI will not detect the latest changes. The structure of the file (sheet names, tables, column names, and data types) should also remain consistent; otherwise, the refresh may fail or return errors.

During the refresh, Power BI applies all Power Query steps again (filters, transformations, calculated columns), ensuring that the dataset in Power BI matches the most recent version of the Excel source. This process guarantees that reports and visuals are always based on the **latest available data** at the moment the refresh is triggered.

When Excel stops being enough

Excel is an excellent starting point for Power BI reporting, but it quickly reaches its limits when the number of files grows, updates become repetitive, or dashboards need frequent refresh. At that stage, automation becomes essential. Excel can still be useful for one-off analysis, but it's no longer enough for reliable, scalable reporting.

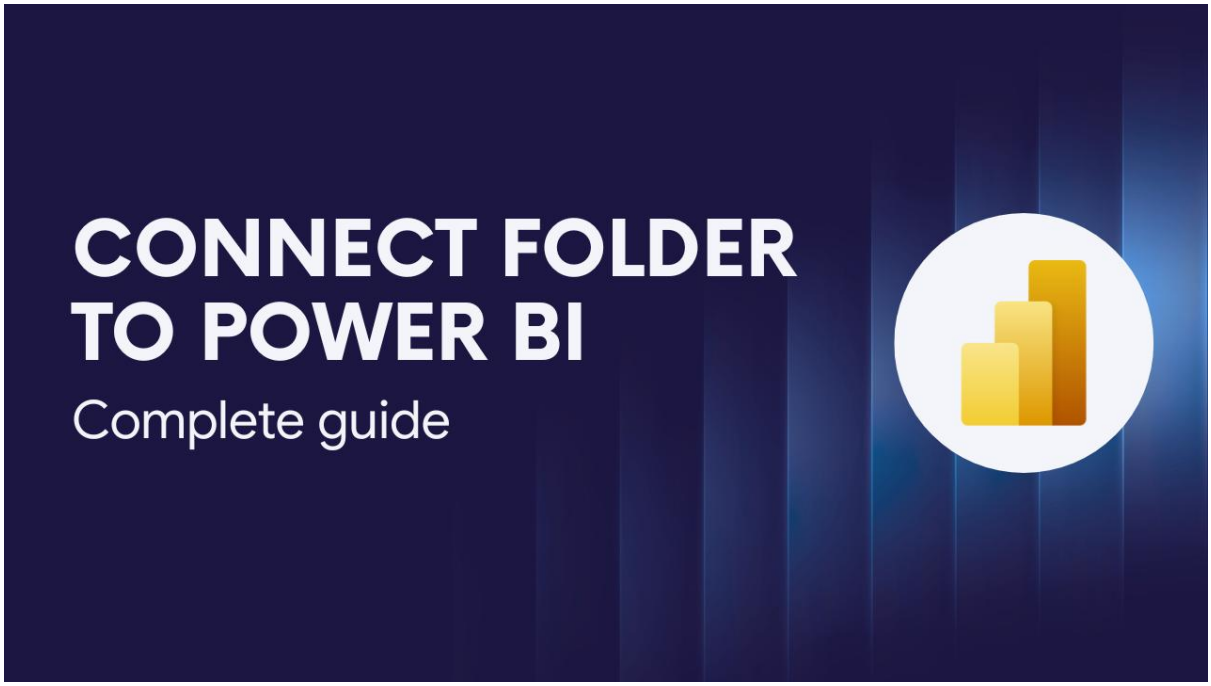
If you want to automate data collection and keep dashboards up to date, tools like Catchr can send data from multiple marketing platforms to Power BI with a clean, consistent structure, so you work with a ready-to-use dataset instead of managing files.

Conclusion

Excel works very well with Power BI, as long as it is used as a **data source**, not as a report. A clean structure, consistent formats, and simple conventions prevent most issues marketers face when building dashboards. Getting the Excel foundations right avoids unnecessary complexity and makes Power BI reporting far more reliable.

Connect multiple files and folders in Power BI

Learn how to connect a folder of files to Power BI to automate recurring updates and manage weekly or monthly marketing exports efficiently.



Many marketing platforms generate recurring exports, such as weekly performance reports or monthly SEO data. When each new export replaces the previous file, maintaining a Power BI report quickly becomes tedious. Power BI can connect to an entire folder, not just a single file, allowing you to automate updates by simply adding new exports to the same location.

In this article, you'll learn how folder connections work, when to use them, and how they help automate recurring marketing reporting.

Why connecting a folder in Power BI changes everything

Connecting a folder fundamentally changes how you think about reporting. Instead of rebuilding or re-importing data every time a new export is available, you create one report that automatically includes all files placed in a specific location.

For marketing teams, this is especially useful for recurring exports such as weekly Google Analytics reports, monthly paid ads performance, or SEO data split by period. The report becomes stable, while the data evolves over time.

This approach removes repetitive manual work and makes reporting far more reliable.

How to connect a folder in Power BI

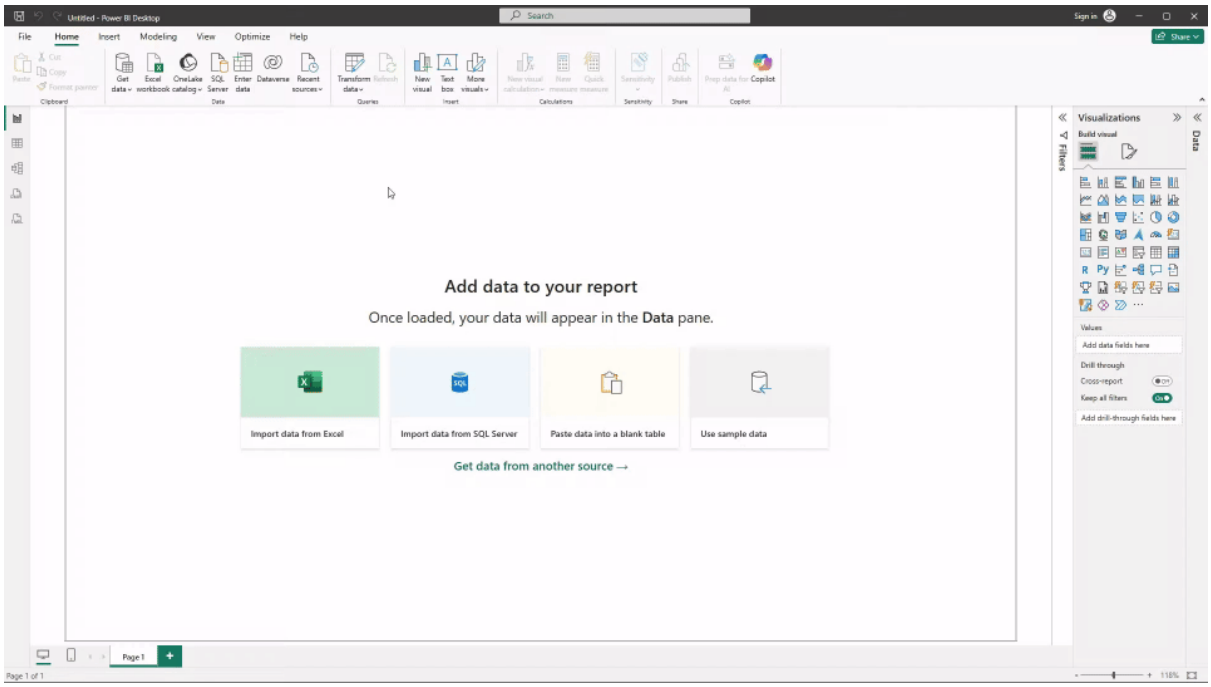
Folder connections are surprisingly simple to set up, as long as the files inside the folder follow the **same structure**.

Step-by-step: connect a folder in Power BI

To connect a folder, all files inside it must use the same format, such as CSV or XLSX. Once this is ensured, open **Power BI Desktop** and start the folder connection process:

1. Click **Get Data**
2. Then choose **Folder**.
3. Select the folder that contains your exports.
4. Click **Combine and Load** (or Combine and Transform) data.

Power BI will list all files found in that folder and propose to **combine** them. When you confirm, Power BI automatically appends the data from all files into a single table.



Once loaded, your report is connected to the folder itself, not to individual files.

When folder connections make sense

Connecting a folder works well when all files:

- Come from the same platform or export logic
- Share the same columns and data types
- Represent the same type of data over time

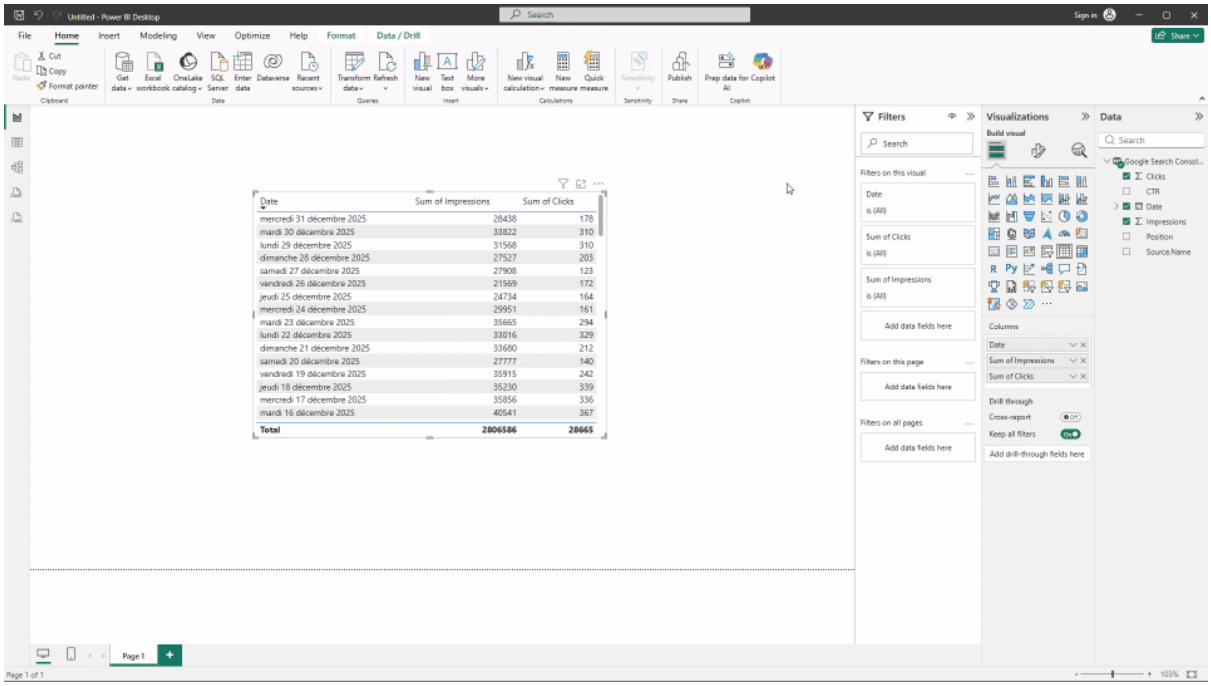
If file structures change from one export to another, Power BI won't be able to combine them reliably.

Automating weekly or monthly updates with folder patterns

Once a folder connection is in place, adding new data becomes very simple.

How Power BI handles new files

When you drop a new file into the connected folder and refresh the report, Power BI automatically detects the new file and appends its data to the existing dataset. Older files remain included, and no manual changes are required in the report.



This makes folder connections ideal for recurring updates.

Naming conventions that make automation work

To keep folder-based automation reliable, naming conventions matter. A good practice is to use one file per period, with a consistent and descriptive name.

For example, exports like ga4_user_acquisition_2024_01.csv, ga4_user_acquisition_2024_02.csv, and so on make it easy to track data over time while keeping the structure unchanged.

Avoid renaming columns or changing formats between exports, as this can break the refresh process.

Common mistakes when connecting folders

Folder connections are powerful, but a few mistakes can cause issues. Mixing files with different structures, renaming columns over time, or deleting older files without understanding their role can break reports or change historical results.

Another common mistake is editing the combined query without understanding its impact, which can lead to confusing errors later.

Keeping file structure stable and changes intentional is key.

And of course, as for the import of a .CSV or .XLSX, you must prepare your file, clean columns, adjust formats, and avoid blank or unreadable signs (for example, use a comma instead of a dot for decimal numbers).

When folder-based automation is not enough

Folder connections are a major step forward compared to manual file replacement, but they still rely on exports and local file management. When reporting involves many platforms, frequent updates, or shared dashboards across teams, this approach can start to feel limiting.

At that point, fully automated data pipelines and connectors become the natural next step.

Moving from file-based automation to fully automated data pipelines

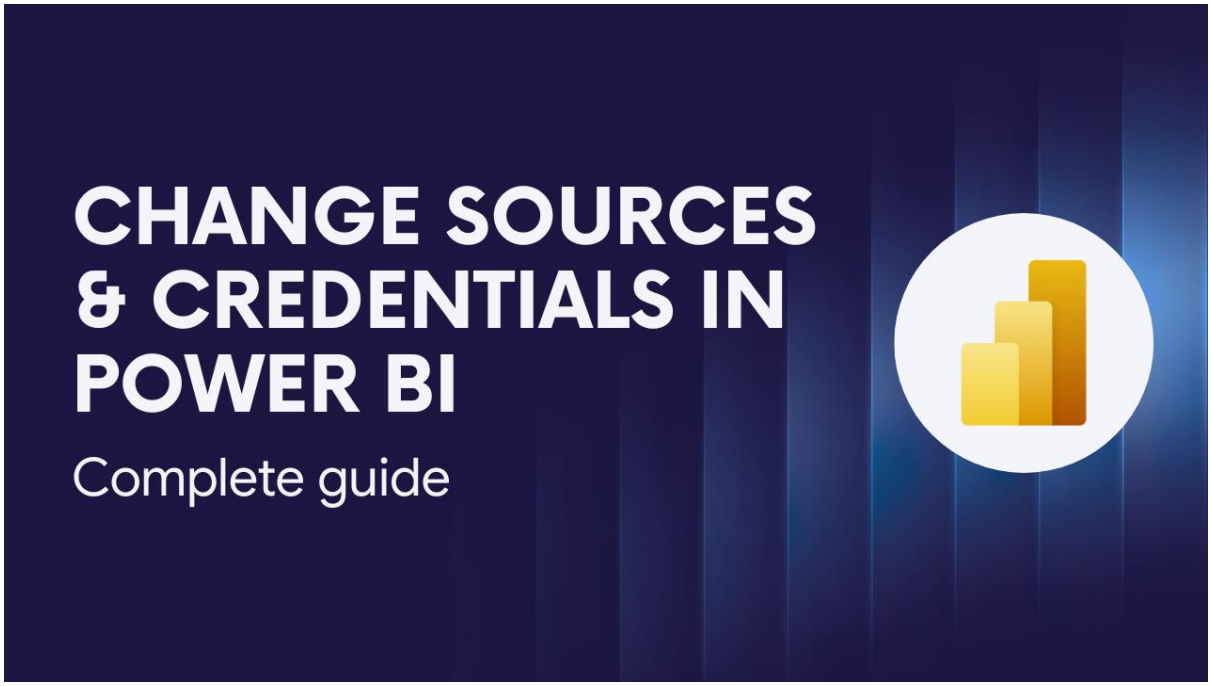
Folder connections help reduce manual work, but they still require managing exports and files over time. When reporting needs grow and teams want more autonomy over their data, automated connectors become a natural next step. Solutions like Catchr handle data collection and refresh from multiple marketing platforms and send ready-to-use datasets directly to Power BI, removing the need for folders altogether.

Conclusion

Connecting a folder in Power BI is one of the most effective ways for marketing teams to automate recurring reporting without adding complexity. It removes repetitive manual work, keeps reports stable over time, and prepares teams for more advanced automation. When used with consistent exports and simple conventions, folder connections offer a powerful bridge between manual reporting and fully automated data workflows.

Change data source & credentials in Power BI: Guide

Learn how to change a data source in Power BI, fix broken file paths, and resolve common refresh issues related to credentials and permissions.



As you start working with real data in Power BI, it's normal to encounter situations where a report no longer refreshes correctly. Files are moved, folders are reorganized, passwords change, or access permissions are updated.

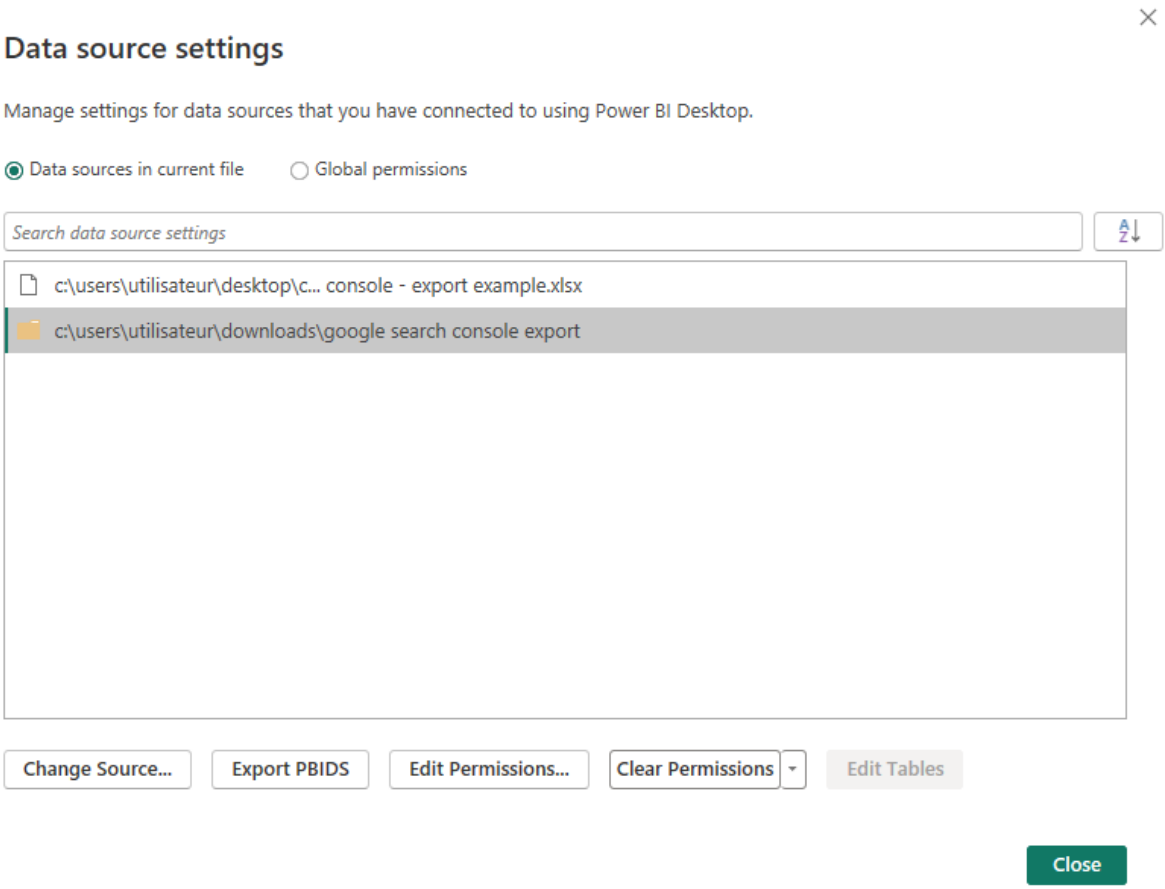
The good news is that these issues are common and usually easy to fix. Power BI provides dedicated tools to update data sources and credentials without rebuilding your report or losing your work.

This article explains how to change a data source, fix broken paths, and manage credentials in a simple, marketer-friendly way.

Why data sources sometimes break in Power BI

Data source issues usually happen because something changed outside Power BI. The report itself is rarely the problem. Common reasons include:

- Files or folders were moved, renamed, or transferred to another computer or shared drive.
- Credentials expired or changed, for example after a password update or a new user taking over the report.
- Permissions or privacy settings prevent Power BI from accessing or combining data sources the same way as before.



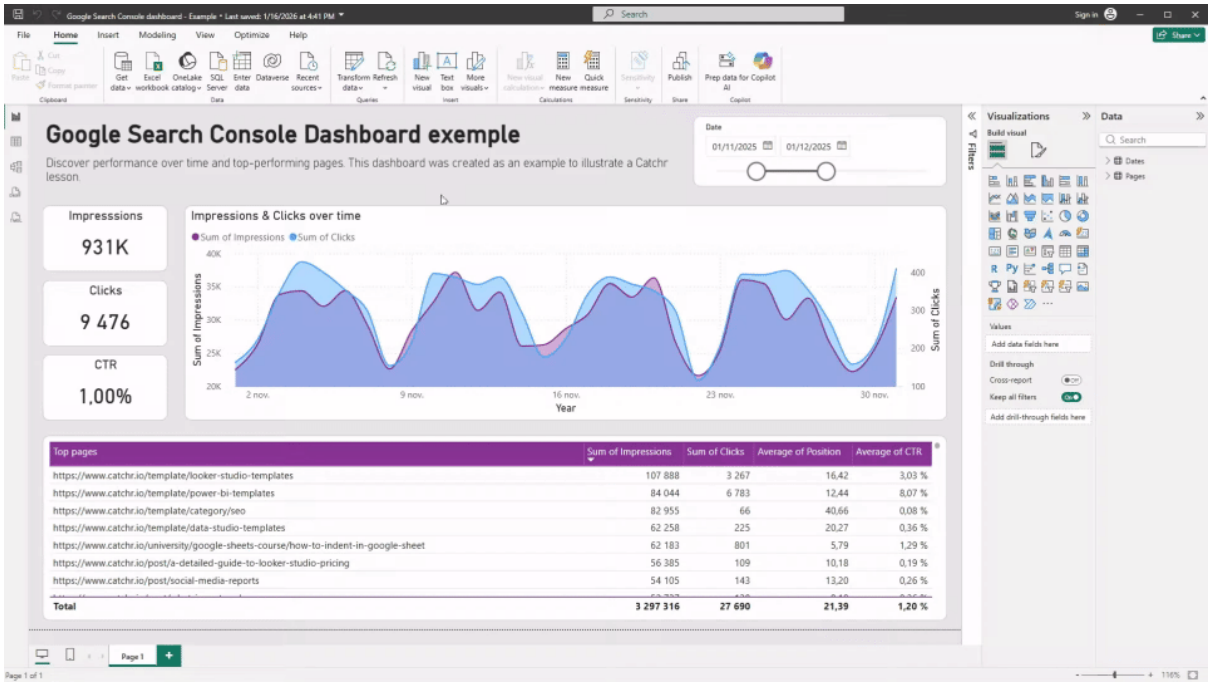
Understanding these causes helps you troubleshoot calmly and avoid unnecessary rework.

How to change a data source in Power BI Desktop

When a data source changes, you don't need to rebuild your report. Power BI allows you to update paths and connections directly.

To do this, open your report in Power BI Desktop and:

1. Go to **File**
2. Then, **Options and settings**
3. Finally, **Data source settings**. From there, you can see all sources used in the report.

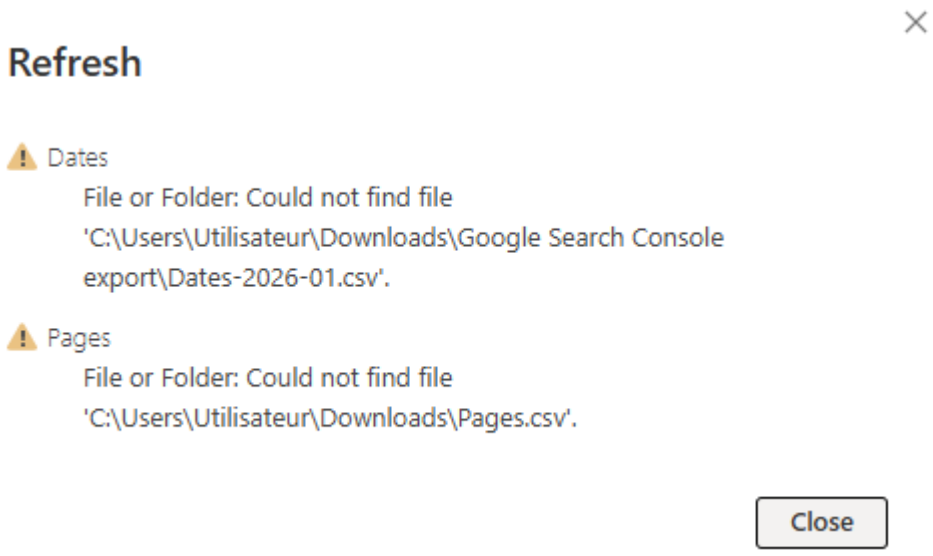


You can select a source and change its path, for example to point to a new file or folder location. Once updated, Power BI applies the change across the report, keeping visuals and KPIs intact.

This is especially useful after moving files, switching computers, or migrating data to a shared drive.

Fixing broken paths after moving files or folders

If Power BI can't find a file or folder, it will usually display an error during refresh. This does not mean the report is broken.



Power BI is simply looking for the data at the old location. By updating the path in **Data source settings**, you can tell Power BI where the data now lives. Once the correct location is set, the report refreshes normally.

This is why consistent folder organization is important, especially when working with multiple exports or shared reports.

Managing credentials in Power BI

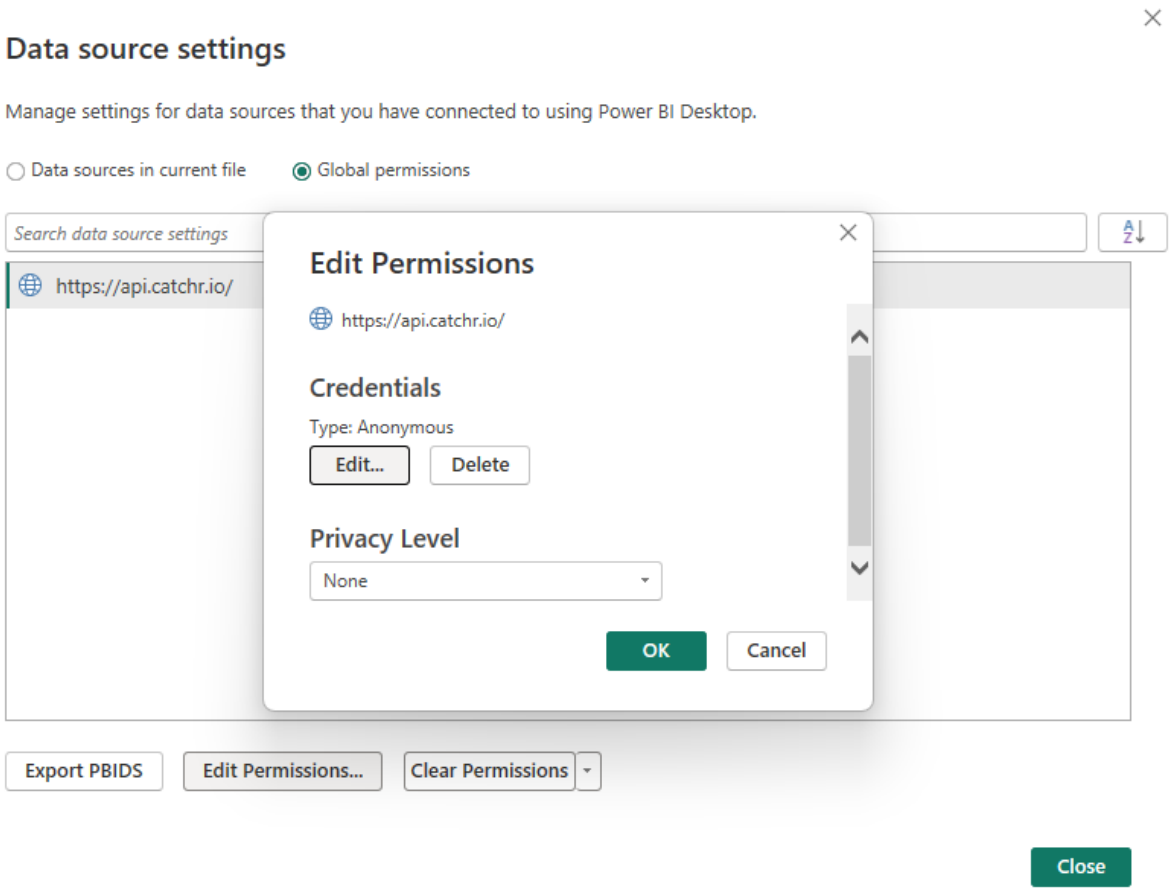
Power BI stores credentials for each data source so it can refresh data automatically. When access details change, Power BI may ask you to sign in again.

What credentials Power BI uses

For each source, Power BI stores:

- The account used to access the data
- The authentication method
- Permissions associated with that account

Credentials are managed per data source, not per report page or visual.



Updating or resetting credentials

If Power BI prompts you to sign in, or if a refresh fails due to access issues, you can update credentials:

1. Go to **File** tab in Power BI
2. From **Data source settings**
3. Select the source, choose **Edit permissions > Edit** (beside Credential section)
4. Sign in again with the correct account.

This process is safe and does not affect your report structure or visuals.

Understanding privacy levels at a high level

Privacy levels in Power BI define how data from different sources can be combined. While the concept can sound technical, marketers usually only encounter it when mixing files, folders, or online data.

In most cases, Power BI's default settings work fine. If prompted, choose consistent privacy levels for sources that are meant to be combined. This ensures Power BI can refresh data without conflicts.

There's no need to overthink this early on. Privacy settings can be adjusted later if needed.

Common mistakes to avoid

Some issues happen because of simple but avoidable mistakes. Rebuilding a report instead of fixing the data source is one of the most common. Others include editing queries without understanding the impact, mixing personal and shared credentials, or ignoring refresh warnings.

In most cases, the solution is already available in **Data source settings**.

Conclusion

Data source and credential issues are a normal part of working with Power BI. Files move, access changes, and permissions evolve over time. Knowing where to update paths and credentials allows you to fix problems quickly and confidently, without starting from scratch. Once you understand these basics, Power BI becomes much more resilient and easier to maintain in real marketing workflows.